

British romanticism

First generation of british romantics: Wordsworth, Coleridge

Second generation: Lord Byron, P. B. Shelley, Keats, M. Shelley

British romanticism was shaped by 3 historical events, known as revolutions:

- Industrial Revolution →romantics where pioneers of ecology →they were against the ind. rev. (it was changing the british landscape, and society)
- American Revolution (or American War of Independence)
- French Revolution

Industrial revolution

First industrial revolution was only in England →and it was impacting massively on british society and landscape

New social class: factory workers, who were highly exploited (long hours, poor wages)

Romantics criticized it because (they were detractors):

- the social injustice it was bringing
- the pollution

American war of independence and French revolution

Romantics were champions (supporters) of political freedom →tended to be in favor of democracy

The 13 colonies became an independent republic →not monarchy

Governors were chosen by people through elections

The french rev. was an act of freedom

Wordsworth and Coleridge started as progressive →they were in favor of the revolutions

But then became more conservative

Wordsworth was in favor of a threshold for people to vote →he thought that only people with a certain education could vote

He changed his opinion because he understood that revolutions are ineffective and lead to violence only

Second generation romantics kept their radicalism → never became conservative
They also died young → Byron and Shelley died in their twenties
They were also atheists → it was uncommon and even a crime at the time

American War of Independence - 248

George III ruled for 60 years → long government → in the end he developed a mental illness, which prevented him from ruling

War of independence began in 1775 → some were rebels (Patriots) and with UK (Loyalists)

The declaration of independence was actually not the reality → many people did not have rights

Adam Smith's theory is at the center of capitalism

He also studied the specialisation and division of labor → he anticipated Fordism

The motor of economy is the individual, not the state, by doing his own interests

Adam Smith founded Liberalism

First Industrial Revolution - 250

It involved Great Britain only → the later ones involved the whole Europe

In addition the first and second were different because of

- time
- countries
- sectors

The first involved the textile sector and transportation

Coal mines were concentrated in the midland and north England

Mushroom towns → cities met to host factory workers

There were no trade unions to defend the rights of workers

Enclosure made farming intensive → at the beginning peasants were in opposition

Newcomen invented and patented the steam engine → it was improved by Watt

The water frame allowed workers to produce stronger threads by applying less physical work. Moreover it allowed the production of 100 percent cotton clothes

During the industrial revolution more and more people started to migrate from the country to mushroom towns

The competition was about how could build the fastest and most reliable locomotive

George III was an Hannover → this dynasty began when the last Stuart Monarch (Anne I) died without children (1714)

The Hannover came from Germany → the first one was George I (he couldn't speak English, only German)

He was helped by the prime minister → then this position remained

In 1780 he suffered a mental confusion known as the royal madness

In the last years of his kingdom he was still the king, but his son ruled

After the French Revolution, England had to fight multiple times the Napoleonic Wars

Nelson was in charge of the navy → Wellington was in charge of the army

The press coined the name "Peterloo" → it criticized the government because it was fighting Napoleon in name of justice and democracy, but then opened fire on civilians

There was a strong migration towards the cities → the rural areas had less inhabitants and these zones were called the Rotten Boroughs

They still had many seats in the parliament, which was unfair because they were less

This was fixed with the Great Reform Act

Starting from 1836, Victoria ruled for 64 years

Augustan poets = neoclassical poets

They wrote in the first half of the 18th century in Britain

They were interested in the Greek and Roman poetry

Their poetry was complex from a conceptual and linguistic point of view →

- conceptual: it was rich of allusions to classical poetry and lots of figures of speech
- linguistic: they used a lofty style → there was a prevalence of Latinized syntax and high sounding vocabulary

Romantic poetry differs → usually the language is more accessible and the poetry was more subjective → it was more about feelings and emotions

Subjectivity is the main feature of Romantic poetry

Augustan poetry: example "The Rape of the Lock" by A. Pope

Romantic poets were more interested in the Middle Ages → Augustan poets absolutely not

In Augustan poetry nature is presented as something controllable by humans thanks to their reason

In Romanticism nature is presented as an uncontrollable force

Burke was an Irish philosopher and thought that there existed 2 types of nature

- picturesque or beautiful → cosy

- sublime nature →destructive nature, that causes fear and ammiration

Romanticism

In Neoclassicism (Augustian age) nature was perceived as something controllable
→humans are endowed with reason

In Romanticism it is not possible

For Augustans the most powerful human faculty is reason

For Romantics it is imagination →it is what makes us humans

Coleridge (coauthor of the Lyrical Ballads (first edition 1789)) →he travelled to Germany and studied philosophy

He believed that there were 2 types of imagination:

- primary: allows humans to understand reality
- secondary: more powerful faculty, allowing humans to recreate a new reality

Before Romanticism a good poet was a good copier?? →in romanticism originality played an important role

Childhood was considered as the most important stage during life →children have the sharpest imagination

Romantics were also against child labor because it was dangerous and because in this way children skipped their childhood

Romanticism emphasized individuality →there was interest in the outcast and rebel
Romanticism followed in Rousseau philosophy →the myth of the noble savage???
→man is naturally good, but civilization corrupts

English romantic poems were set either in the past (often in the middle ages) and in exotic places (far away from Britain)

Escapism = desire to escape the time one lives in, that is considered unjust

Reality was also considered an expression of God = pantheism →others were atheists

Augustan poetry was characterized by poetic diction (complex language and figure of speech)

Romantic poetry is more readable →syntax was not latinized and the words used were not so high sounding

Romanticism comes from romance, the languages such as Italian French etc...

In the beginning it had a negative meaning (extravagant, unreal) →but in the 18th century it became neutral and referred to picturesque nature

Relationship between the feelings of the speaker and the nature surrounding →his

feelings reflect into reality

Wordsworth said that nature was a source of consolation for mankind

Wordsworth

First generation of romantic poets → the members of the second died young in tragic circumstances

He was born in 1770 in a lake district, area in the north of England → near the border with Scotland → characterized by lakes, woods, and rivers → but was impacted by the industrial rev.

He had a tragic life → he lost his parents in his childhood → he was then raised by relatives → he was close to his sister Dorothy → together they had long walks and he also wrote poetry to her

He was a brilliant student → he attended Cambridge University

As a young man he was a radical → he supported the French revolution → he even decided to go there and witness

There he met a woman, with whom he had a daughter but not married → he then became disappointed of the revolution, which was deranging into pure violence

He then decided to leave France → and prepared all the paperwork necessary for his lover and daughter to travel to England

But the borders closed and he was extremely disappointed → this changed also his political view → he became more conservative and critical of revolutions

He was a peculiar conservative: he was also an environmentalist, he was against the poor laws (1834, established workhouses)

They were institutions that had to host homeless, but there they had to work hard in exchange with room and board

The living conditions were also terrifying

Workhouses were expected to be terrible, because they had to convince the poor people they had to improve their social condition

This is in line with the Protestant work ethic → God approves hard work

He also believed that people without an education shouldn't vote

In England he married another woman, with which he had 5 children

His daughter never married and lived with his family

Wordsworth became a very famous poet, he was also appointed a Poet Laureate (the official poet of the British Empire)

The Poet Laureate was also expected to write poems for public occasions

Wordsworth is known for the Lyrical Ballads (a collection of 23 poems), some written by him, others by Coleridge (coauthorship)

There were 3 editions:

- 1798 anonymous
- 1800 with preface
- 1802 enlarged

The 2 most notorious ones are Tintern Abbey (Wordsworth) and the Rime of the Ancient Mariner???

Tintern Abbey

It has to do with a walking tour Wordsworth and Dorothy had in Wales → here they visited the ruins of a monastery (Tintern Abbey)

It was an abbey destroyed in 1534 following "The Act of Supremacy" → it was passed by King Henry the VIII (Tutor), which made England an Anglican country → Henry broke away from the Church of Rome

Monasteries and abbeys were destroyed

The two visited the ruins and Wordsworth wrote a poem about that

In Tintern Abbey Wordsworth reflects on the passing of time and on the fact that nature has taken control of the ruins

Nature is eternal, meanwhile everything humans create is ephemeral

The Lyrical Ballads had to make up for political failures (such as French Revolution) and wanted to achieve their own revolution, a cultural revolution

It is democratical because

- it is a ballad about common people (not heroes, nor aristocrats) → Wordsworth wrote mainly about peasants
- really simple language

Lyrical Ballads

They wanted to achieve a cultural revolution →non violent, because they were disappointed in the french revolution

It is revolutionary because the characters are common people

Moreover the language was simple →so that more people could understand it

It is also a peculiar title →it is oximoric, contradictory: poetry tends to be of 2 kinds:

- lyrical →feelings and emotions of the speaker (the lyrical eye) →examples are sonnets (14 lines), oaths (no fixed number of lines) and elegies (no fixed number of lines, main topic is death)
- narrative →relates a story in verses →tend to be longer

It is oximoric because they are intimate accounts of life in the english country side

They are about stories of common people in the country side but expressed in a lyrical way, with a focus on the feelings

It is oximoric and also hybrid

Question

Poems are about ordinary lives about ordinary people coming from the country side →they are lucky, because they live near nature

The language used is similar to the one people actually used →it is more emphatic and purified from his difects

He uses the couloring effect of imagination to write in an unusual way

Poets have sharper sensibility and imagination + better understanding of human nature

Introduction Lyrical Ballads - page 191

"The Rhyme of the ancient mariner" is a narrative poem →not a lyrical one, like the other Lyrical poems that result in intimate accounts of

In the countryside people where under no social constraints →so they were more pure →moreover they lived in nature →their emotions were more true

The language is a simple one, but it is purified from grammar errors and curse words

The poet in order to write needs to be in a situation of tranquillity →the poet never writes about powerful experiences while they are taking place

He writes after, in a situation of tranquillity

Biographia literaria

It is a long philosophical autobiographical (he reflects on his own biography) essay, written in 1817 by Coleridge

Typical subjectivity expressed during romanticism

Coleridge and Wordsworth (after writing the Lyrical Ballads) their friendship cooled down and Coleridge became critical of Wordsworth literature

For him it was too sentimental and simplistic (Wordsworth's writings)

In this extract they talk about the birth of the lyrical ballads

They moved together to write them

They both reflected on the dual nature of poetry:

- it was supposed to be realistic
- at the same time, it was supposed to be interesting →through the use of imagination, which sometimes broke away from realism

They managed to combine these two contradictory aspects of poetry in the lyrical ballads

They made an agreement →Coleridge was going to concentrate on the supernatural →in the rhyme of the ancient mariner there will be supernatural characters (like ghosts)

Suspension of disbelief →the reader was required to apply it →Col. wanted the reader not to worry about the realism of what they were reading, just enjoy the reading
In order to achieve that →in Coleridge's works the frame is realistic, but with some supernatural aspects

Wordsworth had to concentrate on the everyday life of peasants in contact with nature

We are seven

Typical aspects of the lyrical ballads:

- simple language, used in everyday life, but purified from grammar errors
- children represent the purity of the life far away from societal conventions and of emotions in the countryside
- the little girl is described as the typical peasant
- it is set the country side (the cottage is a typical house) and natural elements, such as the sea, the tree and the sun-set

She is a so innocent girl that she hasn't comprehended the meaning of death → in fact, she plays by their grave

The narrator has a more realistic approach

She talks about her everyday life

Emotions felt by the girl and the lyrical I / narrator are relevant

Prof notes

It is made of quatrains → a four-line stanza → but the last one is of 5 verses

Quatrains is the typical structure of a ballad → which is a narrative poem

A story is being told, but there is a focus on the emotions → hybrid nature of the "Lyrical ballads"

The verses/lines are written in either → iamb → the first one is with accent, the second one no:

- iambic trimeters: what should | it know | of death? → 3 poetic feet (called iambs) → each iamb has 6 syllables
- iambic tetrameters: her hair was thick with many a curl

Iambic trimeters is made of 3 iambs → first one being stressed, the second one is unstressed

It is written in alternate/intelocking rhyme

Stanza 1

And feels its life in every limb → she loves life even if she is in tragic conditions (for ex. her father is not mentioned)

What should it know of death? → rhetorical question → a child should know nothing

of death

Line 3 →alliteration of L and a consonance in F

Alliteration = consonant is repeated at the beginning of each word, in consonance not necessary

Stanza 2

Line 3 →consonance in H

Stanza 3

Physical description, that lets us understand that she is poor

Alliteration of W at line 2

However, she is still beautiful and almost angelic

Stanza 4

The dialog begins →typical of ballads →in middle ages they were learned in memory
→easier to remember with dialogs

Stanza 5

And two is an anaphora

2 of her siblings are sailors

Stanza 6

Line 4 →consonance in M

Line 4 to 4 →are run-on-lines because of enjambement

Dialog and stanzas are typical of ballads

Stanza 7

The narrator speaks →he says that he can't understand the point of view of the girl

Line 4 →alliteration in M

Stanza 8

The narrator insists

The girl is so compassionate that she considers the 2 siblings alive

There is an Aporia = one of the characters raises doubt about what another character

is saying

Stanza 9

They are buried together →side by side, and close to the cottage →emotional and physical vicinity among them all

Line 3 →internal rhyme between more and door

Side by side = diacope = repetition of the same word

Stanza 10

Knit = cucire, hem = orlare, kerchief = fazzoletto →she spends her free time near the buried siblings

Materialistic point of view of the narrator, who is an adult →vs the pure and innocent one of the girl

Daffodils

Wordsworth's most famous poem, published in 1807, but not part of the "Lyricall ballads"

It about a beautiful natural landscape →daffodils are near a lake and describes it poetically

The verbs of the first 3 stanzas are in the past, while the last one is in the present →he remembers the experience in tranquillity

Poetry is a natural overflow of feelings, that happens after the experience is finished. The author remembers his encounter with the flowers as he sits on a couch

He had a sister (Dorothy) who was a best friend and a secretary →she also wrote journal about his relationship with Wordsworth

In the journal it is written that the two went on a walk and saw the field of daffodils →in 1803, 4 years after

Time passes, and he writes about nature afterwards, in a state of tranquillity →he has to feel an emotion similar to the one he felt = 2 conditions to write about the experience

Stanza 1

I →subjectivity of romantic poetry

Line 1 →simile

Line 3/4 →there is a personification →daffodils are described as people (a crowd, a host)

Line 3 →assonance in O, line 4 still in O

Line 5 →alliteration in B

Line 6 →again personification, because the daffodils dance

The verb tenses are past tenses

The description is of a picturesque nature (not sublime in this case)

Stanza 2

Simile →"continuous as"

Line 2 →consonance in K

Line 5 →hyperbole (tenthousand flowers, exaggeration) and alliteration in T

Line 6 →personification of dancing flowers and consonance

Stanza 3

Personification of the waves of the lake →they dance

Diacopy of "gaze" →to look fixatilly

At the same time he was unaware of the powerful feelings he was experiencing

Stanza 4

Inward eye = imagination

Solitude = situation of tranquillity

Last line →consonance in D and in A

The sensation produces the emotions, which are than stored in the poet's memory, a similar emotion reproduces these emotions and can than write

He wrote "Lyrical ballads", "Daffodills", "The prelude" (long meditative poem) →here he reflects on his own life and his relationship with nature

It was published before his death →he worked on it all his life

What is nature to ww? →it is explained in the "Prelude". It is a source of beauty, consolation, literary inspiration and an educator

WW claims to have been educated by nature throughout his life

In the "Prelude" he tells about an event which occured when he was 8 years →he had just stolen a little boat (a mischievious action)

He was sainling, but then he saw that a mountain was following him →for this reason he decide to bring the boat back →example of sublime nature

He felt like he was been educated by the mountain

WW wrote 7 poems of the "Lyrical ballads" →but 5 of them are called the "Lucy poems" →"We are seven" is not part of the "Lucy poems"

The Lucy poems are about lucy, who has died young after living a pure life at contact with nature →she was pure and innocent

Her presence can still be perceived in the countryside area, where she lived

Jamaica Kincaid wrote a novel "Lucy", published in 1990 →the author is from the west indies (carabbbeans) →but she writes in english, because she was born in an english colony

She mentions Wordsworth →but the settlement is contemporary

Lucy here is an 19y ou pair girl, who decides to migrate to USA

It is a post-colonial novel →2 requirments:

- it has to be written by a writer coming from a previous colony of an european country (there are also of france, germany, ...)

- it explores the relationship between colonizers and colonized people

Coleridge - page 300

Coleridge and Wordsworth were friends, and also collaborated → they created strong bonds

Friendship was a substitute of family → some of them had difficult familial situations (like Blake, Wordsworth, Keats → they lost close relatives)

Shelley and Byron were shunned by their families → because they had an unconventional lifestyle, not approved by the aristocratic families they came from

At some point they started to disagree → Coleridge wanted to write more elaborated poetry, and considered Wordsworth's works simplistic

Christabelle → is a gothic poem (with gothic elements, not in the style)

Gothic novel

Gothic literature: mainly made up of novels → it is an expression of pre-romanticism
The first gothic novel was "Castle of Otranto" → written by H. Walpole (1764)

Walpole was the son of the first British prime minister

Other important gothic novels are:

- "The Monk" → Lewis
- "The Mysteries of Udolpho" → Radcliffe (female author)

The rise of the novel → women were central in the development of the novel → first time in history that women took part in the dev. of a literary genre

Women were frequent readers → some of them even wrote them (like Bradly, Aphra Behns → she wrote "The royal slave" at the end of the 17th century)

The royal slave is considered the first novel in English literature

Canon = the authors that are considered the most representative of a nation

Behns was disappeared from the Canon for a long time → she was a female and the novel was anti-colonial

The slave was an African prince who was captured → but he led a riot against the owner → he is a positive character

Gothic novels were like horror stories → dealing with mystery, crimes → they tend to be set in South Europe (in particular in Catholic countries) → demonisation of Catholic Europe → British authors were Protestant

Crimes were committed by villains in dark places like abbeys → the protagonists are mainly innocent people

Some of them have supernatural elements (like ghosts)

Interpretation of the acient mariner

Other interpretation is a colonial one →the albatross is a native of the place and helps the visitors →but then gets killed

The last thursday of november the Thanks Giving day is celebrated in USA and Canada →in 1621 was celebrated for the first time

The piligrim fathers wanted to celebrate their first harvest →in the newly founded colony in new england →they thanked God and the native americans →they helped the piligrim fathers

But then they were persecuted by americans

Colerdge may have made a critique to the persecution of native americans by the colonizers

Pilgrim fathers were puritans →they were persecuted by the anglican king James I →they left in year 1620

P. B. Shelley

Life

He was expelled from Cambridge after publishing the pamphlet

He married really young with Harriet Westbrook →they lived a nomadic life and moved around the UK

He spent some months in Ireland (which so not independent) →the Republic of Ireland (Eire) has existed since 1921 →before it was a british colony (partially)

The northern part (Ulster) was and still is part of the UK

In Ireland Shelley supported irish independentists and made political propaganda that supported the rebellion against UK →it was strange for a british citizen and a member of the upper class

He shared the radical and anti-colonial ideas of Byron

Harriet and Shelley had two children →when they returned to London, they eventually divorced →Shelley fell in love and eloped (run away for love) with Mary Godwin (who will become Mary Shelley)

They went to Switzerland and then Italy, where Shelley died

Mary was the daughter of two relevant british intellectuals of the time:

- William Godwin →radical philosopher known for elaborating the doctrine "radical idealism" = tyranny and monarchy were going to disappear and be replaced by democracy →unstoppable process started with the French Revolution
- Mary Wollstonecraft →proto-feminist (proto because she anticipated feminism, which became a social movement in the 20th century with suffragettes) →she wrote "A vindication of the rights of woman" and the main points are:
 - women lived in a situation of social inferiority and marginality due to their lack of proper education →and her daughter was educated by the father
 - in order to achieve the same rights of men, they had to be given access to education

Shelley was into philosophy and started to visit Godwin's house →he was one of his disciples →and here he meets Mary

Shelley's wife committed suicide because of the abandonment of the husband →he also wanted the custody of the children, but the judge denied it

His children were brought up by Shelley's parents

After Harriet's death he was a widower and was legally allowed to marry another woman →for this reason he married Mary

They had 3 children →2 died

Shelley died too, during a storm while he was sailing in Liguria → Mary became a widow and return to England

He was burried in the protestant cemetery of Rome

Works

Most famous: philosophical and lyrical poems (while Byron narrative)

- "Necessity of atheism" → see previous notes
- philosophical/meditative poems → "Mont Blanc" = meditative poem on nature and its sublime aspects + relationship between mankind and nature
- verse drama (like Byron) → plays written in poetry and philosophical → "The Cenci" and "Prometheys Unbound" → themes: political freedom, self sacrifice, fight against tyranny
 - Prometheus is the titan who rebelled against Zeus and stole the fire for humans
 - Cenci is set in renaissance Italy → the protagonist is a young woman named Beatrice Cenci (powerful aristocratic roman family) and takes place in Rome → she had a violent and abusive father, so she killed him → she knew she was going to be senteced to death, but did it to free his family
 - both characters as symbols of titanism (rebellion against an unjust authority)
- lyrical poems → "Adonais", "Ozymandias", "Ode to the West Wind" → and reflect on freedom and how it is going to triumph over tyranny (radical idealism) → are all political except "Adonais":
 - it is an elegy = poem revolving around the theme of death, inteded as both a personal loss of the speaker and a universal theme of mankind
 - it is about the death of John Keats (another meber of the second gen. of british romantics) → he died at 25 and was Shelley's friend → he caught tuberculosis
 - Adonais is a mythological character, a young man killed by a wild boar → the gods turned the meadow into a bed of roses → Keats and Adonais both died of a premature death and are compared for this reason
- "A defence of poetry" → published in 1821 → it is an essay and written in prose

A defence of poetry

Peacock had written the essay "The four ages of poetry" →main point: in such an age of progress as the 19th century, poetry had become useless

Shelley disagreed and wrote this essay →here he:

- stressed the everlasting importance of poetry →it has to do with the sphere of emotions, which is something that characterizes humans
- defines poetry: "Poetry is indeed something divine. It is at once the centre and circumference of knowledge; it is that comprehends all science."
- "It [poetry] exalts the beauty of that which is most beautiful, and it adds beauty to that which is most deformed...it strips the veil of familiarity from the world" →same point of view of Wordsworth, "coloring effect of imagination" →here it is beauty
- define poets: "Poets...are the unacknowledged legislators of the world." →different from the one of Wordsworth, who says they are men among men →while Blake said that poets were prophets

Main themes

- religion →he was an atheist and God was for him a social construction →the king was considered legitimate because of God
- nature →mainly in its sublime aspects and its relationship with mankind
- politics (largely) →political freedom, showing titanism
- language and its limitations →typical of the romantics of 2nd gen.
- love →a force moving the world and believed in free love →he had different relationships
- was into science and had a passion for philosophy →he embraced Godwin's radical idealism, but he also embraced neoplatonism →he believes in two worlds: the material and the one of ideas →but he says that the material one is inferior but can be interesting anyway
- material reality is like a veil, like a "many-coloured glass" staining true reality →the material world is not dull and is interesting nevertheless

Ozymandias - P. B. Shelley

Remains of the ruins of a colossal statue →it portrays Ozymandias

He owns a large empire and says that someone should be afraid of him →but this clashes with the surroundings, which is a desert only →his empire is reduced to a desert

It is a sonnet (lyrical poem) with 14 lines with iambic pentameters

Ozymandias is the greek name of the pharaoh Ramses II →this other name sounds more exotic

Sonnet consists of a dialog →there is a chinese-box (and a dialogical structure): the speaker is talking to a traveller, who is reading the inscription on Ozymandias's colossal statue

The inscription is composed of Ozymandias's words

It is really subjective (because it is romantic) and in fact starts with "I" →it reflects Shelley's political ideas (he believed in democracy →radical idealism)

This poem is a fierce critique of imperialism →O. created an empire (= ethnicity with rules over other ethnicities) →but what remains of this empire? nothing

Analysis

Antique land = Egypt

The statue is in ruins →and parts of it are missing →there are only two legs without a trunk

Three dots = cesura

Visage = face (french origin) →which is shattered →still you cant recognize an arrogant expression, typical of a tyrant

Malicious smile full of disgust

The sculpture was good at mocking the expression of Ramses →mocking in the sense of imitating or in the sense of making fun →ambiguous and ambivalent passage

It is like Ozymandias is talking →"ye Mighty" →very ambiguous: it might be referring to god or other emperors, who chose despair →probably because he is going to conquer their empires

"Boundless and bare" →alliteration in B

Of Ozymandias's empire remains only his statue →everything that humans create is ephemeral

Radical idealism →empires are doomed to finish

A lot of signs of punctuation →rhythm is fragmented, like the statue is

It is also a critique of imperialism

Ode to the west wind - P. B. Shelley

Introduction

It is an ode = long lyrical poem →without fixed number of lines

There are 5 sections, and each one is a sonnet (made of 14 lines):

- 1-2-3: the west wind is presented as a sublime natural element
 - 1: described the effect of the wind on the earth →it is both a destroyer (it causes the shadding of trees in autumn, so leaves are carried away by the wind →comepared to people following an enchanter) and a preserver (it carries seeds in the soil covered as if they were corpses)
 - 2: described the effect of the wind on the sky →it causes the moving of clouds and storms →clouds are compared to the locks of an approaching storm
 - 3: described the effect of the wind on the sea →the Atlantic ocean and the Mediterrenean sea are mentioned →the second one is picturesque and adapted to humans (along his coast different civilisations had developed and have left landmarks) →the first one is sublime: rough, full of abysses →at the bottom of the sea there is vegetation and are described as shaking of fear because they perceive the coming of the west wind (personification)
- 4-5: presented as a political symbol

Section for starts at line 43

Analysis of section 4

Lyrial I →romantic

Dead leaf is referring to the first section →and cloud to section 2 →and wave to the third

There is a cesura with an exclamation mark →and an apostrophe (referring to the wind)

In these five lines →the author is willing of the fusion with the west wind

Line 43 and 44 →there is the anaphora of "if I were"

After a cesura usually there is a change of topic →in fact there is a nostalgic recollection of the speaker youth →while he was young, he was active and quick as the wind

Line 54: contrast between his active and happy boyhood and the present as and adult man →"thorns of life" is a metaphor for the setbacks of life

On too like thee →the speaker like a young man →now a "heavy weight of hours"

Politically speaking Shelley is an idealist and has optimistic views →but in his life he was pessimistic

Analysis of section 5

He is asking the wind to make him a lyre (musical instrument, symbol of poetry)

The poet is longing for a fusion with the wind, which is defined as spirit

Now he wants the wind to carry around ideas of freedom →to quicken their diffusion

His political ideas are like a prophecy

Last line →there is a rhetorical question (it is obvious that spring will follow winter)

Thanks to the wind he will be able to change the world

Recuperare 1 ottobre

Lucy

She has relocated in New York →she has a conversation with her boss, who was talking about spring and daffodils →this makes her remember something about her childhood

She was a pupil

She was complimented on her pronunciation →one can understand that she was not a native speaker

It is common for post colonial works to have marginalized characters →for example, among the colonized, women, members of ethnic minorities or children, whose view on reality is more sincere and pure (in a sense)

In her dream she gets "punished" for her act of rebellion →the flowers submerge her
She tried to forget this as a defensive mechanism

Anger →typical emotion of post-colonized people

Post colonial literature can deal with the relationship between colonizer and colonized and historical events such as:

- colonialism →(formally started in 1492, with the "discovery of america")
- imperialism →(1) the political philosophy behind colonialism: an empire, by definition, is made by different ethnicities and a government that rules →(2) others consider it an evolution of colonialism and a much worse version (1900)
- neocolonialism →newer form of col. starting at the beginning of the 20th century →typically brought by the USA, and after WW2 also UK, France, Spain (previous colonial empires on the process of collapsing →they influence elections of colonized countries and control economically by buying raw materials at low prices = indirect but deep political and economical influence)

USA wanted to control the American continent →according to the "Monroe doctrine", USA had the right to do it

France, ... →regarded mainly Africa, but also Asia

USA was bringing neocolonialism in the Caribbean →for this reason Lucy is settled in USA

Coleridge

He lived less than Wordsworth →he had been plying all his life with chronic diseases
He treated himself with opium (it was considered as a drug)
He became an addict →and this had consequences on his literature too
Coleridge in his youth had opium-induced visions, about which he wrote in his poems
→but opium ruined his imagination as time passed

Kubla Khan

It was published in 1816 →more mature phase of Coleridge's literal production than the lyrical ballads

An example is "Kubla Khan", which is a poetic fragment wrote after an opium-induced vision

Fragment because it remained unfinished

It is about a vision about a beautiful asian palace, owned by the mongol emperor Kubla Khan

The palace was huge and elegant, surrounded by a lush garden with bushes and trees of any kind

There was also a spring, from which a river originated →there were also an abyss
→the spring has been interpreted as a symbol of poetic inspiration

The river is the poetry the poet can produce

It is a metapoetic poem = it also deals with poetry

But this palace is also an ivory tower →because it was surrounded by huge walls, that isolated the palace from the rest of the world →you could hear echoes of voices coming from the outside

He thought that the poet should lock himself in an ivory tower →the poet had to be less concerned by the real world

In a passage of "Biographia literaria" Coleridge talks about the writing of Kubla Khan →before he had taken Laudanum (a mixture of wine and opium)

He had the vision and then started writing →but then he was interrupted by a friend who visited him →when he started to write the poem again, the inspiration was gone and he couldn't finish it

As a young person he was a radical →he supported the french revolution

With Robert Southey he realaborated a political project →they wanted to create "Pantisocracy", a new community founded in america by 12 couples (and then start the population)

In Pantisocracy women were supposed to have the same right as men, and private property had to be abolished too

This never took place

Southey was considered a major romantic →now it is considered a minor

After his radical youth, he became a conservative later

- "Lyrical ballads"
- "Christable and other poems" (which includes Kubla Khan) →christable is a gothic poem, whose protagonist is the witch Christable
- "Biographia literaria" →philosophical and autobiographical long essay →here he elaborates his theory on imagination

Rhyme of the ancient mariner

It is a long narrative poem (not lyrical) →specifically, it is a ballad, but also a cautionary tale in verse

The first ballads were written in the middle ages →they were very popular, because they were meant for common people →they couldn't read, so minstrels or storytellers recited and sang ballads in streets and squares

- they were written in quatrains
- the language was simple
- full of repetitions (to be learned by heart and be comprehended more easily)
- they had a dialogical structure (dialogs were frequent)
- about tragic events →they reflected the life of the people of middle ages

During Renaissance they lost their central role →theatre was the most famous entertainment method

Ballads were transmitted orally →only in 18th they got written down →and also poets wrote them (called literary ballads), but were more complex and refined as the ones of the middle ages

It is cautionary because it teaches a moral story →it teaches the reader to respect nature (or you will get terribly punished)

The mariner was disrespectful towards nature →now he has to spend his life by warning others not to commit their mistakes

October 7:

Every aspect of nature is a manifestation of God →so it has to be respected

There are 7 sections and there are 2 narrators:

- main external 3rd person omniscient one
- the mariner (first person)

The poem presents both realistic and supernatural aspects →the supernatural aspect requires a suspension of disbelief by the reader

Plot

Plot →page 301 ex. 1

After the violent storm an albatross appeared, and the ship started moving again →it was like a messenger sent by God to help the crew

The mariner was not grateful →he kills the albatross

The mariner for this reason get punished →the ship stops moving (in the equator area) and they run out of water

There are only water snakes that swim around their ship and no other signs of life

Then they are approached by a phantom ship →there are two ghosts (Death and Life-in-Death), and they cast dices with the lives of the mariners

Death wins the life of the mariners, and Life-in-Death wins the one of the ancient mariner →he will live but be dead and will have to tell his story to others

After the death of the mariners, the ship is still not moving →it moves only when he blesses the snakes and understands the importance of nature

Open ending →but it implies that the mariner will spend his life as a wanderer and his sense of guilt will end with his death

Killing of the albatross

There are some prose parts, that anticipate the content of the stanzas

Ship is personified (she)

'th = ancient way of saying 's

Stanza 1 →the external narrator speaks

Stanza 2 →next of kin = close relative of the bridegroom (the male spouse)

Stanza 3 →first and last line: consonance in H, and dialogical structure

Stanza 4 →the mariner mesmerizes him →stood still = alliteration in S →like a 3 years child = simile

Stanza 5 →line 2 alliteration in c →line 3: inversion

Stanza 6 →the mariner becomes the second narrator →kirk = archaic word for church →diacope of below

Stanza 7 →line 2: inversion →sun referred to with "he": personification →line 3: consonance

Stanza 8 → general narrator is talking
 Stanza 9 → line 2: simile and inversion → merry minstrelsy: alliteration
 Stanza 10 → he hypnotizes with his eye
 Stanza 11 → the narration continues, by the equator there was a storm (he and tyrannous, personification) → storm = sublime nature → then storm with animalisation (has wings)
 Stanza 12 → sloping = inclined → line 2: consonance in W → and long double simile: the storm is someone chasing their foe (enemy, the ship here) and is so close that can walk on its shadow
 Stanza 13 → at the south pole they find a sublime landscape → anaphora of "and" → ice is green as emerald (simile) → fearful: sublime nature creates fear
 Stanza 14 → no creatures, only ice
 Stanza 15 → they feel overwhelmed by ice (sense of oppression) → diacopy of ice → animalisation of ice (growled, roared, howled) → last line: simile, like a dream
 Stanza 17 → diacopy of round
 Stanza 18 → the albatross becomes a constant presence
 Stanza 19 → moon in the night: example of picturesque nature Stanza 20 → anticipation of destiny of the mariner → he will have to live like a dead man

A sadder and wiser man

Moral of the whole poem
 The mariner is talking to the guest → there is an apostrophe
 Even beasts have a soul → pantheist vision of the world, that Coleridge will abandon in his later life
 Later he became more conservative (politically) and also more orthodox religiously (abandoned the pantheistic view)
 The very conclusion is relevant to the cautionary tale
 The guest grows morally → he becomes wiser

2 most relevant british romantic painters are Constable and Turner
Constable tended to put the focus on picturesque landscaped, while Turner on sublime ones

Second generation of british Romanticism

They were:

- Byron
- P. B. Shelley
- Mary Shelley
- J. Keats

They are called members of the second generation because they were younger →they were born 20 years after Wordsworth and Coleridge

They also died young, under tragic circumstances

Byron died for example while he was in Greece, as he prepared to fight against the Turkish Empire →he died from a malaric feaver, during training

P. B. Shelley died during a storm, while sailing on a ship he owned, in Liguria

Keats died of tuberculosis →he was burried in a protestant cemetery in Rome

Politically speaking →they were radicals →they didn't have the time to become conservative

They were also critical of Coleridge's and Wordsworth's conservatism as adults

Lord Byron

1788-1824

He was the member of a powerful aristocratic family →his family was so prestigious that he had a seat in the british parliament

Parliament was made of 2 houses:

- house of commons →MPS (members of parlament) are elected through general election
- house of lords →whose seats are inherited

However his childhood was not happy →his parents neglected him →he had been raised by his calvinist nanny (she brought him up and influenced him from a religious point of view)

She was fundamental in his upbringing (not education)

He then attended university →then he became extremely famous in London →he was like an idol

- literary fame →his works were appreciated and were best sellers
- biographical fame →his lifestyle was scandalous →some criticized him for this reason, others appreciated his freedom

He was married, but had several lovers →he believed in free love →he despised marriage as an institution

It is also believed that he was bisexual

At one point he became member of the parliament →however a day a mob (infuriated crowd) attacked his house →some rumors had spread about his homosexuality

It was also believed that he had incestuous relationship with his half sister

He wasn't hurt, but he was so shocked that in year 1816 he decided to leave England for good

For him english society was too narrow minded and moralistic →he had a fall from grace

He moved to the continent (continental europe) →he leaved in Geneva, where he owned Villa Diodati

This villa is important for romanticism →in year 1816 one night he was hosting P. B. Shelley and his wife (Mary)

They decided to have a writing competition →the winner had to write the most horrifying horror story →the winner was Mary Shelley →she wrote only a short tale

Then she expanded it in a full novel in the following 2 years →it is Frankenstein

In the introduction she claims that the story comes only from her imagination →but recognizes that Byron and his husband played an important role

She wrote the tale after a nightmare she had →the dream was inspired by a conversation she had heard between Byron and P. B. Shelley

The 2 were talking about an experiment of Galvani →he tried to make dead frogs come to life with electricity

Byron travelled then in europe →he lived in Venice, Rome, Ravenna →while he was in Italy, he was in touch with italian independetists, who were against the austrian empire

The austrian police found him →so he went to Greece →he was very radical from a political point of view →he was ready to risk his life to help indipendentists (both italian and greek)

He was very athletic →but he was a lame, a cripple →malformation of a foot

He was psychologically touched by this physical disability →he suffered from this

Even his view of nature depended on this disability he was born with →he was fascinated by the sublime aspects, on the other hand he accused nature to be a evil stepmother →she made his life difficult

Nowadays british scholars do not consider neoclassicism and romanticism as in stark opposition →byrond embody this duality and the evolution of romanticism from neo-classicism

He composed romantic and neoclassical works →he was a romantic poet but also neoclassical production

Most famous for narrative production

Romantic works:

- lyrical poems →collected under "Hours of Idleness (ozio)" →he is better known for his narrative ones
- verse tales →narrative poems in verses →most important ones under the collection "Oriental tales" →most two relevant are "The Corsair" and "Lara" →here the character feels strong and powerful emotions, and the atmosphere is gothic →typical main character is the figure of the "Byronic hero"
- "Childe Harold's Pilgrimage" →semi-autobiographical poem →not totally, because the events are loosely based on his life →the protagonist is Harold, an aristocratic young man, who travells on a grand tour in Southern Europe (like Byron did)
- verse plays →written in poetry (not prose), set mainly in Italy →philosophical plays, focusing on political freedom →they were rarely put on stage because are very complex to follow →they are mainly meant to be read →ex. "Manfred", "Marino Falliero", "The two Foscari" →"theatre of words, not of action"

He also wrote neoclassical works, in the form of satirical / mock-heroic poems →written in "ottava rima" (eight-line stanzas)

They satirize the hypocrisy of the british society →he despised them (satire) →ex. "Don Juan", he is an anti-hero (reason for mock-heroic) →he fell in love with many women, ...

The verses followed a specific rime pattern

In writing this works, he was influenced by Augustan poetry, which was mocking

and used poetic diction → he was also influenced by Swift (for the use of satire) and Sterne (for the use of digressions)

Byron

He is more complex from a stylistic point of view?? →he is culturally elitist in his satirical poems →he used poetic diction (lofty style characterizing augustian poetry = latinisms, figures of speech)

But also the use of satire, wit and irony →important aspects of augustians poetry and Byron's one

- wit = the ability to relate things in a sophisticated and funny way
- irony = the use of words to express the opposite of what you really mean
- satire = is an artistic technique aiming at exposing and discrediting people's vices by recurring to wit and irony

On the one hand Byron was fascinated by sublime nature →but at the same time it felt resentment because of his physical disability

Byron is the embodiment of the overcoming of romanticism over neoclassicism →they are not in contrast

Titanism = attitude of rebellion against authority that the subject perceives as despotic and unjust →term comes from the mythological figure of the titan (most famous one: Prometheus)

Prometheus has 2 versions:

- the titan creating humans out of clay
- the titan stealing fire from zeus to donate it to humans (more important version to romanticism) →for this reason he was tied to a rock for eternity (an eagle ate his liver every day) →he represents the punished rebel for a right cause

The tone in the romantic works is titanistic, idealistic, rebellious, fascinated by Nature, gothicism, nationalism →he was a champion of political freedom (not of individuals, but of peoples)

The concept of the exotic has changed with the development of means of travel →italy was an exotic place at the time

The neoclassical works are more realistic →skeptical realism, because his pessimistic point of view on society

The byronic hero is the typical character of byron's romantic poems

"Lara" → The Byronic Hero

Proud, mysterious, dark, rebellious

Scoreful towards society → for him common people tended to lack from sensibility

He is mysterious

He helps to be admired, not for pity

Lara is the sequel to another oriental tale → "The corsair"

The protagonist is a Spanish count and Lara is the name of the possession he owned

He decides to leave his privileged position and travel the world

Then he returns to his lands → in the meantime they were usurped by another aristocrat

Similar to the corsair → why ???

The byronic hero is considered by scholars as an alter-ego of Byron himself → but it is not an autobiographical figure (this would be too far fetched)

It is a romantic character, but also a controversial one

Characteristics of the Byronic Hero - Analysis of the text

- 1 he is controversial because he conjured up mixed feelings in people
- 2 there was something to be loved and feared → he is dangerously attractive → line 2
- 3 he was a taciturn → he didn't talk much, and people tended to speculate on his secrets for this reason
- 4 he had got a mysterious past
- 5 lineage → he has an aristocratic background
- He is a 6 misanthrope (a hater of his kind) → he hates human beings
- 7 he had a sneer (sardonic smile) painted on his face
- 8 he doesn't want to show his vulnerability
- 9 now he is disdainful of humanity probably because he has loved too much in the past
- 10 he felt like he was an outcast (he stood a stranger in this breathing world)
- 11 he usually had dark thoughts (dark imagining) → dangerous thought for himself and the others

- He hates everyone →but 12 has an incredible sensitivity to beauty and nature
- 13 he is a restless soul (line 37, he expands his life in phantom chase →looking for something)
- 14 he feels fiery passions (line 39)
- 15 one the one hand he is fascinated by nature, on the other hand he blames it for all the misfortunes happened to him
- 16 sometimes he blames fate without holding himself responsible, without taking personal responsibility (line 48)
- 17 sometimes he helped others not out of generosity, but to feel superior →sign of perversity of thought
- 18 he has committed crimes
- 19 he is characterized by an attitude of escapism →he wants to leave this wo

The byronic hero represents the romantic hero →controversial figure with few positive aspects

Byron

Satirical neoclassical poems

Beppo - an extract

Is set in Venice → is about an aristocrat, who is believed to have died → he returns to Venice and has to reconquer the love of his previous lover

Here Beppo makes a digression on language → Byron was influenced by Sterne in this → he wrote an experimental novel, called "Tristan Shandy" → so experimental, that he inspired experimental novelists of 20th century

"Tristan Shandy" is full of digressions

The point made is that neo-Latin languages are superior in comparison with Germanic languages → because they sound better

Here he uses a specific stanza → called "ottava rima":

Foot = a syllable

- 8 lines → first 6 iambic pentameters (10 feet) + last 2 hexameters (6 feet), also called "alexandrines"
- rhyme AB AB AB CC

Bastard because Latin developed from Greeks

"Melts like kisses" → figure of speech: simile

"from a female moth" → alliteration of F

"sounds / should / satin (raso)" → alliteration of S → creates musicality

Line 4: personification of syllables → they are breathing → + alliteration in S

Pat in = smooth

Uncouth = (rozzo)

"Like our" → simile

Hiss = sound of the snake

Sputter = spit

Don Juan - another extract

Marriage is love being spoiled → marriage and love don't mix, marriage ruins love

Love is pure, superior → gets spoiled by marriage, just like wine turns into vinegar

It is a digression on the theme of love

In Byron's opinion, it is a hypocritical institution

Line 2 →alliteration in F

Line 3 →alliteration in C

"Like vinegar from wine" →simile

Love is superior to marriage →they only rarely combine

Don Juan is written in ottava-rima

Byron

Life →page 314

He was an unconventional aristocrat with a scandalous life →first people were attracted by this

Then he was surrounded by scandals and debts →so he leaves

He made negative comments of romantic poetry →he defined it unelegant and boring, using even swear words (like against Keats)

He believed in individual freedom and freedom of nations from empires

Childe Harold's Pilgrimage

Page 318

A childe = a young man waiting for knighthood (minor british aristocracy, not the major one, like barons, earls and dukes)

Semi-autobiographical →the adventures of Harold replicate the ones of Byron

Childe Harold is a sort of the representation of the byronic hero

There is a red thread in Byron's works →it is the importance of fighting against political oppression

Main themes:

- journey
- nature →picturesque and exotic, but also sublime →often it mirrors the character's mind and feelings
- freedom →individual, or the one of whole populations from tyrans

P. B. Shelley

Was member of the second generation of the british romantics, along with Byron, Mary Shelley and John Keats

He died really young →he was 30 years old

He belonged to a rich and aristocratic background →just like Byron

He could have a great education →he attended Eton (not a university, but a prestigious highschool, a prep school for university)

Shelley hated his experience there →he did not enjoy his time there →his classmates tended to be posh kids and they were also obsessed with sports

The whole institution was obsessed with sports →but he hated sports, for this reason

he was bullied

He was not into sports, but also had strong political ideas →this being radical clashed against his aristocratic background

Then he enrolled to Cambridge university →he liked the experience from an academic point of view, but in 1812 he published a controversial pamphlet

Its title was: "The necessity of Atheism" →pamphlet = essay (work in prose) about a social/political topic →a specific political idea is argued by the author

It was controversial because this essay was in favor of atheism, which was illegal in those years →he published the pamphlet anonymously →but his identity was uncovered

He wasn't arrested thanks to the connections of his family →but got expelled from the university

His parents were disappointed and cut off their financial support

But Shelley was supported by his two elder sisters, who were close to him

In the pamphlet he claims that atheism is necessary to achieve democracy in society
To him there is no rational proof of the existence of god →so he doesn't believe in god

He also doesn't understand how god can be described as both the god of love (in the gospels) and a punisher god (in the bible) →for him this is contradictory

This theological view became political

European monarchies are based on the "divine rights of kings" →according to which a rightful monarch is one of god's representatives on earth

Monarchy has to exist, according to this →but if the existence of god is denied, then also the existence of monarchy is unjustified

Recuperare 17 dicembre

Questions of Frankenstein

The novel starts with captain Walton, who was exploring the North Pole (he was searching the northwest passage in particular →he wanted to find a passage to access the Pacific Ocean)

He writes to his sister, about his meeting with Victor

Particular circumstances of the meeting: Victor was travelling on a sledge and was freezing to death →Walton saved him

It is a cautionary tale because →Victor starts to tell his story, and the cautionary tale is aimed at Walton

Victor in his life was overambitious, by creating artificial life and not respecting the gods →Victor wanted to teach him lesson, so that Walton would not commit his same mistakes

Also the Rhyme of the ancient mariner is one →the mariner stops people and tells his story as a moral lesson

Father is Alphonse, Caroline is his mother, and has two brothers (Ernest and William), while Elizabeth was adopted by the Frankenstein family

Elizabeth was adopted while the family was visiting Lake Como →here they found a poor family, and among the many siblings she was different

Elizabeth was actually born in Milan, but his mother died and his father went to prison because of the Austrians (her parents were indigentists)

Caroline was moved by this story and decided to adopt her

Victor was smart and curious →this led him to being lonely →and had only Henry and Elizabeth as friends

When he is 15, he saw a thunder →and got fascinated by this sublime event (also a tree caught fire)

His father decided to send him to Ingostadt, where he studies anatomy, philosophy etc. →but Victor was not happy and wanted to remain close to his family

When Caroline dies, she makes the wish that he and Elizabeth would marry in the future

Gennaio 14

At university he studied chemistry, natural philosophy and anatomy →he became obsessed with science and by creating life

To do this, he went to the morgue and analyzed parts of corpses, that he then assem-

bled →the spark of life was given by a thunderbolt

As the result of his experiment, he was in shock and fainted →as he woke up, he saw the creature staring at him and then he ran away

He then meets Cleverel, his best friend, and Victor isn't well →he suffered psychologically and, after his recover, he decided to stop studying science and started to study languages

He realized that his obsession with science had gone too far

Two years pass by →William (youngest brother) was murdered →a maid gets convicted, but Victor thinks it was the monster: he saw a big shadow in the forest and saw the bruises of the strangulation

The maid was executed because they found in her pocket a necklace of William →which was put by the monster

During an excursion on the glacier, he encounters the creature →here is where the Chinese box kicks in: the monster starts to talk about his life in those two years

He talks about his loneliness and his self-education →he also requests a female creature, and to live with her in isolation

The creature went through a process of self-discovery and was taught by the blind father of the De Lacey family

The monster helped them, and he decides to meet them →but when the sons arrive, they attack him →he decides that he doesn't want to have anything to do anymore with humans

He agrees and does research to create a female →he goes to the UK, has a holiday with Henry at the lake district →and then in Scotland

Here he sees the monster creeping from the window, and out of fear decides to destroy everything he had done

The monster responds, that he will be present at his wedding (as a threat)

Victor was then charged with murder →Henry was killed (by the monster) →he was in prison, but thanks to a lawyer friend of his father, he was released

He returns to Geneva, and marries Elizabeth at Lake Como →Victor decided to patrol the exterior of the palace, but the monster climbed the wall and got in through Elizabeth's window

His father dies too →now Victor seeks revenge

Ask for last part

Questions with quotes

- 1: Mary Shelley is referring to the specific night when the idea for Frankenstein came to her in a waking dream or vision.

- 2: Growing up in this intellectual household, Mary was surrounded by books, ideas, and literary culture from birth (her parents were Godwin and Wollstonecraft)

"The white man's burden" is a poem by Kipling →the white man has this duty to colonize areas that are wild = celebration of colonialism

While in Joseph Conrad, colonizers are complete idiots

They have a "sense of displacement" →they find themselves in an environment that is completely different both geographically and culturally

Quotes from Mary Shelley

- 3: Realism claim: The work isn't merely supernatural terrors but based on a plausible scientific premise exempt from typical ghost story disadvantages. Coleridge comparison: Yes, similar attitude—both blend imagination with verisimilitude requiring "willing suspension of disbelief."
- 4-9: Pict, sublime, sublime, sublime, pict
- 11-16: To gods with unlimited powers, who can control nature. The analogy is with Adam: the creature compares himself to him.
- 17-19: Show hubris, overreaching human limits, defying natural order, Promethean theft of divine prerogatives (creation, conquering death) for glory.
- 21-23: Convergence: Both seek glory, knowledge, have ardent curiosity, risk everything. Divergence: Walton seeks geographic discovery; Victor seeks scientific creation. Both seek forbidden knowledge and learn dangers of overreaching too late.
- 24-27: Reveals tabula rasa (blank slate), sensory confusion, existential crisis about identity/origin, gradual learning through experience, shaping by culture/books.
- 29-30: initial desire for a connection and a companionship. Final revenge and hate
- 31: they are indissolubly bounded to each other, and only the annihilation of one of them can end this connection.
- 33: initial denial of reality that turns in a gradual acceptance, and the realization of the presence of grief in the world.

Teacher's notes

Ask note of first two questions

Question 3

Partly it is a gothic novel (which was however becoming less and less popular), while there is a blending of supernatural and realism

For Coleridge fancy and imagination were different, while are generally considered

synonyms

There are some gothic elements, but it is more realistic than the typical gothic novel
Coleridge requires a "suspension of disbelief" in *Biographia literaria* →but here she makes clear that Frankenstein has a realistic frame →there a focus on the importance of realism

Question 13

"I became myself capable of bestowing animation upon lifeless matter." →reference to Prometheus →see both myths

1: His liver get eaten every day from an eagle

2: He creates humans from clay →and Victor impersonifies both: he creates life but goes beyond human limits

Question 15

Biblical reference →the creature compares himself to Adam, but finds himself completely different →while Adam was beautiful, he is horrible and isolated just like his creator

Question 17

Titanism = act of rebellion against an unjust power →Prometheus

Victor wanted to achieve glory and benefit humanity, by eliminate disease

Question 18

Reference to Prometheus

Question 19

Victor is titanitic, but also Walton →he wanted to explore new places for humanity
The third figure is the creature, that rebels and seeks revenge

Question 21

Victor also wants to achieve glory →not only to overcome human limits →Victor with knowledge, Walton with exploration

Question 23

Victor warns Walton →this is what makes it a cautionary tale

Question 24

The creature is talking about its first months of life →it emerges the absence of a family, and he is like a tabula rasa →he had to learn everything by himself
Outside he was a grown man, inside just a baby →and his cognitive state was
He was haunted by questions like "who was I?" →he sought his identity

Question 26

He initially had only perception →and he could understand this stimuli and sensations only by refining his intellect
He developed from a cognitive point of view, and developed the ability to memorize
He learned by reading and taught it to himself

Question 29

At the beginning he wanted to enter society, but then decided to remain isolated

Question 30

It is the creature who has power, and has become the master of its creator →he defines Victor as a slave

Question 31

Life is an essential theme →but also death, a lot of characters lose their life
The creature believes that their mutual misery (creator and creature) will only end when one of them dies

Question 33

One of the most touching quotations
Specific theme and universal one →Victor is reflecting on the death of his mother →but then the reflection becomes universal
It is death: it happens to everyone and there is a reflection on mourning and its stages

The different stages of loss are a state of shock at first, then little by little you achieve acceptance of the death of this person and then you keep living

Question 36

Progressive (actually radical) statement →there were only two democratic countries: usa and the swiss republics →here Victor says that it is better to live in a republic than in a monarchy

Here the lower classes are free and not slaves like in monarchies

Question 39

"the sanguinary laws of men" this phrase is Russonian because it is related to the "Good savage myth" →man is born good, but gets corrupted by civilization

Question 40

It is racist because Victor seemed fine, because he was white →he calls the locals as savages

Question 43

Reflection on language, typical of the second generation of romantics →it reflects on the limitations of words, that cannot express everything

Main points about the novel

The genre is hybrid →combination of epistual and gothic novel (even if she wanted to overcome this genre) and it is an anticipation of sci-fi

It is also a chinese box →characters tell stories

We know that we are in the 18th century →there are no chronological references, and the letters are missing the century

There are different places in which it is set:

- Geneva: main setting, when it comes to Victor's childhood (which was a place of happiness) and adulthood (but then becomes a city where he met tragedy as well: his parents died and his brother was strangulated here)
- Ingodstadt: where he studies and works on his plan of creating life artificially →most scenes are at night here →place associated with darkness (physical and metaphorical: he was obsessed and isolated)

- North Pole: here he meets Walton and where he (and creature perhaps) die
- minor settings: UK, Scotland, the Lake District and Northern Ireland (here he was accused of killing Henry, and remained in prison for 3 months)

Other themes are sublime and picturesque nature, then science → through science the impossible is achieved → but it is also dealt ethically → scientists cannot research everything they want

There have to be ethical boundaries

The creation of life is another topic → but it is a perverted creation of life → because brought up by a scientist and not god

He also tries to remove the right to women to procreate (according to some feminist critiques)

Another theme is titanism

The pursuit of glory and knowledge → both Walton and Victor search → they were driven by the overcoming of human limits but also by glory

The creature is a metaphorical figure → because he rebels against his creator → and his legitimate pursuit of knowledge, because he wanted to understand who he was

This is also a tribute to Locke's theory of understanding → the creature had to learn through experience and a cognitive evolution is developed

William Godwin was also an anarchist

Walton is a double of Frankenstein (see page 278-79)

Reasons for inspiration: Galvani's experiment, personal anxiety and love for ghost stories

The creature is like the good savage of Rousseau

"The rebel" page 283

Non-romantic literature

Romanticism in Britain is known for being mainly poetic →but there were also prose works, like:

- the gothic novel
- "Frankenstein" by Mary Shelley
- the historical novel, invented by Walter Scott →who also influenced Manzoni in his writing "The Betrothed"

The novel of manners

Jane Austen is another important author of this period, but is not romantic →she wrote novels of manners, like "Pride and prejudice", "Emma", "Sense and sensibility", and "Northanger abbey" (novel and parody of the gothic novel)

The gothic novels began to be written in the 1760s →but then became less trendy (Frankenstein is gothic only partly) →readers got tired of this genre, so she mocks it. The characters are not round, but flat →they are not complex →these attributes of characters were invented by Forster in "Aspects of the novel"

Flat characters cannot undergo an evolution and their psychology doesn't change →while round characters have more complex psychology

The protagonists of Jane Austen's novels are young women of the middleclass living in the country side →they are usually smart and moral, and their goal is to find the right husband

These novels revolve on the themes of marriage, love, money (these girls have to have a proper dowry) →but these women are unconventional and independent: they want to marry the right person

Third person omniscient narrator is frequent in novels of manners

Irony is the most typical ingredient →and these novels are still successful nowadays. Richardson wrote epistolar novels (like Frankenstein partially is), but also wrote some novels of manners

The historical novel

Romantics are interested in the past →in the middle ages and the greek world, as a sort of escapism

Walter Scott's more significant novels are:

- "Waverley" → regarding the history of Scotland → Jacobite risings around 1715/1745 → in 1707 the Act of Union and the UK was established → and Scotland lost its independence and became part of the UK → Scotland and England had been enemies since ever → Jacobite risings wanted to make Scotland independent again with Stuarts
- "Ivanhoe" → regarding the history of England → it is set in England following the year 1066, year of the battle of Hastings, when the Anglo-Saxons were defeated by the Normans of France → they invaded and started ruling → the novel is about the tensions (complex social political relations) between these two ethnic groups

Scott was interested in historical crisis, and the effect of historical events on common people

It is interesting also linguistically: the novels are written in standard English, but also uses dialects to achieve realism

Normans and Anglo-Saxons also spoke different languages → and French became the official language of the country

Victorian age

It is a long phase of British history going on from 1837 (Victoria's accession to the throne) - 1901 (Victoria's death)

Her reign was the second longest in the history of UK → the first one was Elizabeth the 2nd (1952-2022)

During this period the country experienced imperial and economic growth and UK became the most powerful country in the world → but common people lived in poverty = social problems

There are three parts:

- early Victorian period = until 1850
- mid Victorian period = 1850-70
- late Victorian period = 1870-1900

Early period

The toughest years were the ones of the early period → the 1840s are known as the "hungry forties" = decade of unemployment (industrial crisis) and bad crops in the countryside

The situation was particularly bad in Ireland → in these years there were the "Irish

famines" →mainly in the non-UK ireland, which was a colony →northern was part of uk because the majority was anglican

The rest of ireland was a colony →they were catholics

There was probably an illness striking potatoes →the population was reduced to one third →many died, many migrated to North America and Australia

There was also problems with factories in the uk →the industrialization was unregulated, owners of fabrics could do everything they wanted and factoryworkers were exploited

An important political movement that emerged was the "Chartist Movement" →it was a political movement founded in 1839, with the publication of the "People's Charter" →the chartists demanded universal suffrage, fewer working hours, higher wages
They were not successfull, but their ideas started to be put into practice in the following decades

Mid period

The situation improvedd →more favorable economic situation worldwide and the state start interveing by passing important reforms, which improved the living conditions of the lower classess and created less sociali comflicts (chartists were sometimes violent)
Some reforms were:

- Poor laws →controversial: institutions (mentioned in Oliver Twists) like the workhouses were created →they were meant to host poor people, where people had to work →there were for men and for women and children →so families were separated →and the living and working conditions were terrible →but there was a social phylosophy, coming from the portestant work ethic (poor people were lazy and didn't have god in favor): people had to live a miserable life in a workhouse, to find the motivation to earn more
- Reform acts →lowered the income threshold in order to be allowed to vote
- Education acts →started obliging children under a certain age to go to school rather than working →elementary education was compulsory until the age of 9, then the age was increased →but victorian schools were terrible as well: corporal punishment was common

Victorian Age - Recuperare appunti del 30 gennaio

First reform act said that children had to go to school until 9

Trade-union acts → established trade unions as legal and permanent organizations

Factory acts → wages are higher and working hours are reduced

The government financed the Suez canal and colonial expansion in Africa/Asia

There was scientific progress

Men were the providers → and women were expected not to work

Prostitution was really popular → but sex was a taboo

Great exhibition of 1851 → the crystal palace was created, but now it doesn't exist anymore

Questions

1 Who had the idea of planning the Great Exhibition? → it was Victoria's husband (prince Albert)

2 What was his aim? → show Britain was top-dog → political stance

3 What is the name of the first item (a technological device) mentioned in the video?

What was it used for? → copying telegraph to reproduce the signal many miles away
→ facts simile

4 What is the name of the second mentioned item (a wonder)? Where did it come from? → world largest diamond from India

5 What is the name of the third mentioned item (a facility)? What was it like?
→ toilets inside the exhibition and public toilets with towels and other things

Charles Dickens

He was born 1812 and died in 1870

He was born in the South of England →moved to Kent as he was a child →so he lived in the countryside for some years

These biographical experience had literary consequences →his novels tend to be set in the city, to explore the social issues of the Victorian age

However, some scenes are set in the countryside →and they tend to be happy →the countryside it is an idyllic place

Finally he moves to London →he spends the rest of his life here (and part of his childhood)

He came from a middle-class family, but his father ended up contracting a lot of debts →as a result, Dickens had to dropout school and work in a factory of shoe-polish = traumatic experience

This influenced some of his novels →some of his characters worked in factories

The financial situation didn't improve and his father ended up in a debtors' prison →so his family had to move to a workhouse

Then, they received an unexpected inheritance →the father was able to pay off his debts →so Dickens could stop working, they moved back to a house and Dickens continued attending school

He graduated from high school, but didn't attend university →at first he was a clerk (impiegato) in a law firm

This experience was important also for his novels →he talks about justice in England and how it is unjust →Oliver Twist goes to court, and he wasn't treated rightfully by the judges

Then he became journalist →covering news regarding trials and the parliament →Court and Parliament reporter

His first literary work was a collection of humorous articles, published under the name of Boz →"Sketches by Boz"

As he became successful, he became a professional writer →he kept being a journalist, but also wrote fictionary novels

His first novel was "The Pickwick Papers" →a humorous novel, about a group of rich middle-class men passionate about sport

They travelled around England for the sake of sport and lived a series of misadventures

His attitude towards Victorianism: he shared the ideals of the age (industriousness, family, etc.) →but he was aware, that there were tragic issues →like prostitution, child labor, etc. →he explores these themes

He had also 9 children, but then he fell in love with another woman (an actress) →Dickens's main hobby was theatre

In the novels there are brilliant dialogues →one can see the influence of theatre in novels for this aspect

Eventually he separated from his wife, and lived an official relationship with this woman →but, being a proud victorian, he felt guilty

He was a celebrity in the UK →he received public backlash because of this decision regarding the separation

He was also famous in the USA →here he gave public readings of his novels and university lectures

He was also a workaholic ??? →he worked really hard, and had a consuming life →he died pretty young

His novels can be classified in early and late ones.

Early:

- The Pickwick Papers
- Oliver Twist

A Christmas Carol

A Christmas Carol →novel, whose protagonist is Scrooge (stingy and greedy old man) →he accumulates money, not to be generous →and hated christmas, and considered it a waste of money →scrooge = party pooper →but over the course of the novel, he changes

His employee is Bob →he is happy and has a numerous family →but Tiny Tim is sick (one of his children, and is going to die, unless someone pays for his medical bills)

Scrooge has a profitable business, and doesn't want him to take some days off

On the night of christmas eve, he is visited by 4 ghosts →the first one is the one of his previous colleague, who is wearing chains →he says, that if scrooge doesn't change he will end up like him

Then he is visited by the ghosts of Christmas Past, Christmas present and Christmas future

The first one shows him his childhood →his parents died and he was left behind by his sister

It also shows him his previous fiancée, who broke up with him because he only thought about money

And also shows his boss when he was an employee →here he loved christmas

Then, in present, he learns about the life of Tiny Tim and his family →and also shows him other people having fun during christmas

Then the future one shows him his funeral →where nobody was there and everybody was occupied in taking possession of his belongings

So in the end he changes, starts to love christmas and pays for Tiny Tim medications
Dickens contributed to the creation of the cult of christmas

- david copperfield →this is a novel of formatio →he achieves happyness without compromising and without losing his good heart
- bleak house →about the iniquities of victorian laws
- hard times
- a tale of two cities
- great expectations

There is usually a third person omniscient narrator →and uses irony to pass judgement on his characters

Victorian novelists tend to privilege this type of narrator in general

The typical setting of Dickens' novels are english cities →mainly london, but also, like Oliver, who was born in an unnamed industrial city →but moves to London???

They can be also ficitonal cities →but parts of his novels are also set in the countryside, which is idealized and idillic →there are no paesants starving

His characters belong to the middle and working class

His characters tend to be flat →Scrooge makes an exception, he changes during the novel

Dickens' tone is melodramatic →the characters had to go through tragic situations, but in the end they find happy endings, for which he uses plot twists →critized for this

Melodramatic because his novels teach moral lessons ???????

Also comic the uses humour irony and wit

Some characters were so memorable that their names entered the english vocabulary

Questions

1) Describe the circumstances of Oliver's birth. Oliver was born in a workhouse in a nameless town. His mother, a young, exhausted woman found lying in the street, died almost immediately after giving birth to him. She left no name or identification, leaving Oliver an orphan from his first moments.

2) Where was baby Oliver sent after his birth? What was his life like there? He was "farmed" out to a branch-workhouse run by a woman named Mrs. Mann. His life there was miserable; the children were subjected to systematic neglect and starvation. Mrs. Mann kept the majority of the parish funds intended for the children's food and

clothing for herself.

3) Who was Mr Bumble? Mr. Bumble was the parish beadle, a minor church official with authority over the workhouse. He is portrayed as a pompous, self-important, and hypocritical man who delights in his petty power and mistreats the paupers under his care.

4) Where did Oliver end up when he turned nine? What was his life like there? Upon turning nine, Mr. Bumble removed Oliver from Mrs. Mann's care and took him back to the main workhouse. Life there was harsh and monotonous; the inmates were slowly starved on a diet of thin gruel and forced to perform hard labor, such as picking oakum.

5) What happened to Oliver after the "Please, Sir, I want some more" accident? After Oliver famously asked for a second helping of gruel, the workhouse board was scandalized. He was immediately confined to a dark room and a notice was pasted on the gate offering five pounds to anyone who would take him off the parish's hands as an apprentice.

6) Who tried to obtain Oliver? Mr. Gamfield, a chimney sweep, tried to take Oliver as an apprentice. However, the magistrate refused to sign the indentures because he noticed Oliver's genuine terror and realized that chimney sweeping was a dangerous trade often fatal to young boys.

7) Who was Oliver finally given to? He was apprenticed to Mr. Sowerberry, the parish undertaker.

8) How was Oliver welcomed there? He was not welcomed warmly. Mrs. Sowerberry commented that he was small and would cost money to feed. He was fed scraps (broken bits of meat) that the dog had refused and was forced to sleep among the coffins in the workshop.

9) Who did Oliver meet first thing in the morning after spending his first night at the undertaker's? He met Noah Claypole, a charity-boy who worked for Mr. Sowerberry. Noah was older, larger, and immediately bullied Oliver, enjoying the chance to feel superior to someone else (since he himself was usually looked down upon).

10) What new mansion was Oliver assigned one day? What first funeral scene did he witness? Oliver was promoted to become a mute (a professional mourner) at children's funerals because of his melancholy expression. His first experience was the funeral of a young woman in a destitute slum, where he witnessed the raw grief of the mother and the indifference of the officials.

11) Why did Oliver and Noah fall out badly one day? What happened next? They fell out because Noah insulted Oliver's dead mother, calling her a "regular right-down bad 'un." Enraged, Oliver attacked Noah, despite being much smaller. He beat Noah, leading Noah to scream for help.

12) Who else took part in Noah and Oliver's fight? What was its outcome? Charlotte (the maid) and Mrs. Sowerberry rushed in to help Noah. They beat Oliver and locked

him in the dust cellar. Mr. Bumble was called to discipline him, and eventually, Mr. Sowerberry beat Oliver as well to appease his wife.

13) What did Oliver decide to do the day after? What was the journey like? Who did he meet right before leaving? Oliver decided to run away to London. The journey was grueling; he had to walk the entire way (70 miles), suffering from hunger, cold, and bleeding feet. Before leaving the town, he passed the workhouse and saw his old friend Dick, a dying child who blessed him and wished him well.

14) Who did Oliver meet in a village north of London? What was he like? In the town of Barnet, Oliver met Jack Dawkins, better known as The Artful Dodger. He was a young boy who acted and dressed like a grown man, wearing a coat that was too large and a top hat. He had a swaggering, street-smart attitude.

15) What was Oliver's first impression of London? Oliver found London to be dirty, smelly, and crowded. The area the Dodger led him through (near Saffron Hill) was a maze of narrow, muddy streets filled with filth and poverty, quite different from the grand city he had imagined.

16) Who was Oliver welcomed by once in London? Where? Describe him. He was welcomed by Fagin in a dirty, smoke-filled house. Fagin is described as a "shriveled Jew" with a villainous and repulsive face, matted red hair, and dressed in a greasy flannel gown. He was cooking sausages when Oliver arrived.

17) What happened the very first morning Oliver stayed at Fagin's? What characteristics of Fagin's personality emerge? Oliver woke up to see Fagin admiring a box of hidden watches and jewelry. When Fagin realized Oliver was awake, he grabbed a bread knife and looked at Oliver with murderous suspicion, asking what he had seen. This revealed Fagin's paranoia, greed, and hidden menace.

18) What did the children living at Fagin's turn out to do for a living? Did Oliver realize it straight away? How did Fagin train them? The children were pickpockets. Oliver was innocent and did not realize this immediately; he thought they made wallets and handkerchiefs. Fagin trained them by playing a "game" where he would walk around the room with items in his pockets, and the boys had to remove them without him feeling it.

19) What would have happened if the kids had returned home having stolen nothing? They would have been punished, usually by being sent to bed without dinner or beaten.

20) How did the two gentlemen react when they realized they were being pickpocketed? Mr. Brownlow (the gentleman reading at a bookstall) realized his handkerchief was gone. When he looked up, he saw Oliver running away (Oliver ran because he was terrified after seeing the Dodger steal the handkerchief). Brownlow shouted "Stop thief!", prompting a chaotic chase.

21) What happened to Oliver in the court of justice? Oliver was dragged before the magistrate, delirious with fever and unable to stand properly or speak in his defense.

He was locked in a cell briefly before the hearing.

22) Who was Mr Fang? Describe him. Mr. Fang was the presiding magistrate. He is described as a disagreeable, bullying, and hot-tempered man who abused everyone in his court and seemed more interested in rushing through cases than dispensing justice.

23) What was Oliver sentenced to at first? Mr. Fang sentenced Oliver to three months of hard labor mostly because Oliver was too ill to answer his questions, which Fang interpreted as disrespect.

24) Who unexpectedly turned up at the court of justice? What happened next? The bookseller who owned the stall where the theft occurred arrived just in time. He testified that he saw the other two boys (the Dodger and Charley Bates) steal the handkerchief, not Oliver. Consequently, Mr. Fang abruptly cleared Oliver of the charges, and Mr. Brownlow took the sick boy home to care for him.

Dickens - Oliver Twist

Oliver is often misunderstood by adults, but he keeps his nature throughout the story
1: he was born in a workhouse and two professionals were present: a surgeon and a nurse →but they didn't have a professional attitude →the nurse was drunk and the doctor wasn't compassionate and thought she was a prostitute

2: he was sent to a branch of the workhouse, that worked as a sort of orphanage →here he was neglected and underfed, and Mrs. Mann kept all the money meant for the kids to herself and took care of the kids only the day before an inspection →during these inspections she also pretended to be nice with them

3: Mr. Mumble is a memorable character →he was the beadle of the workhouse appointed by the board →he was arrogant, cruel, not smart, insensitive 4: he left that branch to join the workhouse itself →he had to learn a trade (as in practical profession) →he had to untwist ropes for the navy 5: they ate gruel (sort of porridge, made of unknown low quality ingredients) →and the portions were tiny →one day one of his friends threatened to eat one of them if he wasn't given enough gruel →so one of them had to ask for more gruel, and the one who had to do it was Oliver →the reaction of the workers was exaggerated →so he got locked up in a room for days and Mr. Bumble hit him and was humiliated in front of other children →he was also donated with 5 pounds 6: first a chimney sweeper tried to obtain him →he was cruel, violent (he describes the way he treats children and the donkey he rides) →but he is desperate for money →the old magistrate decides not to give Oliver to the sweeper

7: he was then donated to Mr. Sowerberry (a good person all in all) and he is an undertaker →he has a wife, who is not nice, and there is also a maid →and also has an apprentice, named Noah (slightly older than Oliver and bullies him)

8: he was given the remains of dog food and he had to sleep in the basement surrounded by coffins →and he was afraid of the dark, and this first night was tragic for him

9: Noah woke him up by kicking the door of the basement →Noah was a charity boy: he did not live in a workhouse, but in a regular house, and was not an orphan, but was still considered an underdog →the parish supported his family (his father was a veteran, who didn't work, and his mother had a humble job) →so he could relate to a person inferior to him (Oliver)

10: then Mr. Sowerberry assigns a special job to Oliver, and becomes a mute (he is a beautiful boy with innocent features) →a mute is present to funeral and remains sad and serious →Noah gets jealous for this →in the first funeral a poor woman died of starvation →her husband was desperate, her children were not particularly aware and her mother was actually happy, because she could participate in the funeral's banquet and was given a cloak

11: Oliver was patient, until Noah called his dead mother a prostitute →so Oliver

attacked him, and Mrs. Sowerberry and the maid fought him →so Mr. Sowerberry had to punish Oliver, even though he knew it wasn't right

13: in the end Oliver decided to flee and went to London (he was born in a fictional city, called Mudfog) →but before leaving, he wanted to say goodbye to his mate of the workhouse, who was to the point of dying, but blessed him →melodramatic because everything bad happens to him →his journey was terrible, and only an old couple gave him food

14: In a village north of London he met a child, called the Artful Dodger, who took him to London to a man who could host him

15: the first thing he saw in London was a slum

16: Fagin was an old man and a Jew, who welcomed Oliver →he was hosting children and trained them as pickpockets →he developed a strategy using handkerchief →and Oliver doesn't realize

17: he saw Fagin putting jewelry in a box and attacks Oliver with a knife →he is an extremely greedy person →racist depiction

Mr. Brownlow gets robbed by the children, and Oliver gets accused by the angry mob and he gets arrested, and is taken to court →in the trial scene, we understand Dickens' critiques to Victorian justice →Mr. Fand, in charge of the trial, is rude and insensitive and unprofessional →but in the end he is not sentenced to prison, thanks to the librarian who saw the scene (was a witness) and testifies, Oliver was didn't commit the crime

The plot of Oliver Twist gets complicated

Oliver gets adopted by Mr. Brownlow →who lives in a beautiful house in the countryside →here he is given food and is educated

However, Fagin and Bob Sikes (an adult too) decide to kidnap Oliver →they are afraid that he will report them to the police →they kidnap him thanks to the help of a little girl Nancy →and he returns to London in Fagin's house

Here he is obligated by them to help them to burglar a house (burglary, burglar) of a rich family, made of a young woman (Miss Rose) and her guardian

During the burglary, Oliver is wounded but again taken back to Fagin's house

Oliver Twist - Plot

Brownlow adopts Oliver

He gives him a comfortable life in the countryside, being educated and having enough food →but he gets kidnapped by Fagin and Bob Sikes, and they take him back to Fagin's lair (cove)

He is obligated by them to participate in a burglary in the house of Miss Rose and her guardian

Oliver gets wounded, but he is then hosted by the two people →however, it was likely that Oliver could be kidnapped again

Nancy this time tells Rose and Mr. Brownlow of the fact that Fagin and Sikes want to kidnap him

Now Fagin's gang is joined by Noah, who had ran away from the house of Sower and stole all the money at home

Noah spied Nancy while she was telling them the two antagonists plan, reported her to Fagin and Sikes and they violently killed Nancy

When people of the neighborhood found out the murder of Nancy, an angry mob wants to kill Bob who dies while escaping

The artful dodger gets arrested and gets deported to Australia →it was a penal colony, where convicts were sent to do hard labor

The melodramatic effect starts kicking in →Bob dies while escaping, Dodger gets deported and Fagin gets arrested and gets sentenced to death

Mr. Bumble loses all his money and ends up in the workhouse himself

The other villain is Monks, who is Oliver's half brother →and wants to deprive him of his inheritance

In fact the mother was a lady who ran away to escape the family while she was pregnant

In the end the inheritance was split, and Monks emigrated to USA, where he lost his money and became a criminal and died in prison = melodramatic effect

While Oliver moves in permanently with Mr. Brownlow and finds out that Miss Rose is his aunt →she gets married and they live a happy life

Quotes

Tender laws of England →use of irony

ASK NOTES ON THESE QUOTES

He uses irony mainly for entertainment purpose →to entertain

Recuperare febbraio 17

Dickens - Hard times

Coke = burnt coal → coal was the fossil fuel used and in northern england there were many coal mines

Gradgrind is a philanthropy → he founds a school, of which he was principle and teacher → he wanted to teach his students only facts, things that are acknowledged to be true
He also had two children and was a widower → he brought up his children only with the importance of facts, and not by developing their imagination → he failed at being a parent

These two children became unhappy → the daughter married a man with whom she was not in love, and eventually separated as he bankrupted

The brother was bad and robbed the husband's bank, and he escaped the law because he hid in a circus

Sissy Jupe the year before, had been abandoned by his father (a circus man) → Gradgrind adopted her and forced the same education of his children → she pretended to follow his educational point of view → but kept her sensitive side, and in fact she had a happy life

Gradgrind looked down at Sissy and the circus (it was a too imaginative and creative reality) → but by the end of the novel, he understands his mistakes as an educator and as a father

Usually Dickens's characters are flat → here Gradgrind is actually round, and is an iconic character

His philosophy of education was materialistic → emphasis on facts only and not on imagination and creativity

Hard times is divided in three volumes → each one divided in chapters

Bounderby was a banker and a factory holder → he considers workers as objects

Utilitarianism is a philosophy that was born in England → Bentham is the founder → everything that is beneficial for the majority of the population, it is necessary good morally

It is materialistic → what is useful is good

Oscar Wilde - Dorian Gray

Extract

First it is Lord Henry who is talking

Aphorism → Beauty is a form of Genius → then other aphorisms → it is only shallow people...

Time is jealous of you → personification of time → his youth is compared to flowers, metaphors → also gold of your days

Lord Henry's philosophy of life is a new hedonism → the purpose of life is to follow pleasure only, and ignore morality and social rules

Henry says to Dorian that he is lucky to be young and handsome, but this will not be for ever → and he will be miserable, so he has to live his age fully

There is a dark prophecy → he will stab the painting and will die because of this

Dorian will exhibit the picture in his living room, but as he notices some changes in the picture, he moves it to his attic

Last statement is his fatal wish

Gothic element → something irrational dreadful happens

The night when Dorian dies, Dorian decides to live a different life → he wants to stop following pleasure → and after taking that decision, he climbs the stairs to the attic

He thinks that the portrait must have started changing → it has become a horrible old monstrous man → but the painting doesn't change, and a hypocritical sneer shows up → he didn't want to change really (maybe)

So he stabs the painting, and transforms in the hideous figure of the painting, while the painting returns to its original state

The servants recognize him only for his rings

British literature on WWI

The first world war is also called the great war → 1914 - 1918 → Italy joins in 1915
UK joins because:

- it needed to support its allies to Russia and France
- rivalry with Germany → it was a dangerous country because:
 - economical → UK was the richest and more industrialized country in the world → but Germany had become competition

- political →britain still had the most powerful colonial empire →but germany was building its empire in africa

The war started in 1914, until 1916 the british army was made only of volunteers →for two years, hundreds of thousands of young men decided to go to the front and fight for their country

Some of them did it out of patriotism, but most of them because they were convinced by pro-war propaganda

Pro-war propaganda worked through articles in newspapers and magazines →young people were invited to leave for the front in order not to look like cowards

There were sit-ins which were trying to convince young men to join the army →young men were stopped

They also gave those young men white feathers, symbol of cowardy →there was a lot of psychological pressure

There were also lots of posters →aim to convince young men to join the war

Britons want you

King of england is pointing to the reader →britons were a celtic population, that lived in england around 100 b.C. →they survived the roman invasion →in year 410 a.D. they regained independence from the roman empire, which ruled between 43 and 410 a.D.

450 a.D. anglosaxons attacked britain (a germanic population) →the populations migrated to wales →then anglosaxons and celtics started to merge

Propaganda did not want to consider the anglosaxons (germanic tribe) as the real ancestors of the english people →they wanted the celts, so they called britons

Take up the sword of justice

Personification of justice →it was honorable and just to join the war →young men had to fight for justice

Beat back the hun

Hun stands for "unni" →germans are compared to huns, that were a barbaric and violent tribe lead by Attila →germans are monsters and barbarians

It is a german soldier, painted as a monster and his hands dirty of blood of innocent people

Who's absent

A man wearing a ? with the uk flag →invites to enlist →and asks who is absent, not gone to the front

Father

Children ask their father what did he do during the WWI →plays on the sense of guilt

In 1916 volunteers were not enough, so all british men aged between 18 and 31 were obliged to enter the british army →conspiction was introduced

Even young men from the colonies tried to be involved

The empire needs men

Propaganda for men from the colonies →symbolism of the young lions (colonies) and old lions (uk)

In this propaganda symbolism is used a lot

Women of britain say work

Isnt all work

Men would have had recreational activities too →not only fighting

Soldiers in WWI did not spend most of their time fighting, but in trenches = terrible living conditions

When they fought, they were fighting against disruptive new war machines (not other soldiers)

They left with some expectations, but they found a completely different situation

Many suffered from PTSD →these soldiers are called shell-shock

"To go over the top" = to attack the nearest trench →"no man's land" is the area separating two trenches

Maggio 13

PTSD = post traumatic stress disorder →this form was called "shell-shocked", and they are called "shell-shocked soldiers" →and they were not treated

In case of severe shell-shock they were recovered in the "Craiglockhart hospital" →they were sent here not in order to let them adjust to civilian life again, but to treat them to send them again to the front

Some survived and return to the UK as war veterans, who after the end of the great war had a hard time in adjusting to civilian life again

British women also played a central role in the british war efforts →they were not soldiers, but they contributed:

- by replacing men in factories
- by joining the propaganda system
- they were sent to the front as nurses →there is a lot of british literature of female authors that were nurses in WWI

After the great war women were rewarded by being granted the right to vote (in 1919)
→initially only women over 30 could vote, now over 18
War poets = professional poets who ended up in war

Two war poems

Both authors fought during the war, and reflected on their experience at the front in some of their poems

The soldier - Rupert Brooke

He was part of a poetical movement known as "georgians" → he is a "georgian poet" → they wrote their poems between 1910 and 1915, when George V was king of the UK

The georgians tended to write about the English countryside → they considered it as the essence of "Englishness" → influence of Wordsworth

Rupert Brooke wrote this before leaving for the front → he is enthusiastic and is a volunteer → he died some weeks later after writing this

This poem is an Italian sonnet → made of 14 lines, grouped into an octave and a sestet (the English sonnet is made of 3 quatrains and a couplet)

At the beginning of the 20th century started to write poems in free verses (no forms, no rhymes) → however Georgian poems were traditional

First line → assonance in "o" and alliteration in "d"

Second verse in "f", in line 3 there is a caesura

Richer dust because it is where an English soldier died

Personification of dust

Reference to the English countryside → English / England = is a polyptoton (repetition of words that share the same root)

The sestet is more metaphysical

Eternal life is a sort of after life

This is an idealistic poem

Dulce et Decorum est - Wilfred Owen

The title is a partial quotation of the Latin poem of Horace (Orazio) → however the quotation is ironic, there is nothing good about war is the message

There are rhymes (so no free verses) → but the verses are iambic pentameters (or maybe soldier in this one not? ask)

4 stanzas

First one sets the scene

"Like old beggars" is a simile → he talks about a group of soldiers → unheroic representation

"Like hags" (old women) →another simile

"Sludge" = mud

Verse 3 and 4 →they have gone over the top, they attacked →now they return to their trenches

"Limped on " = zoppicare

Line 6 →diacope of "all"

In the second one, a gas attack is described

One was not quick enough to wear the mask

"Under a green sea" →simile →the gas turned the air green →he sees his comrade dying

Stanza 3 is about the trauma, that seeing his comrade dying has created in the writer
Consonance of "s", first line

Stanza 4 conveys the message of the whole poem

"Like a devil" →simile, his fate is like the one of a devil

Message is that pro war propaganda should not exist →it convinces young men to leave for the front

The view of line 1 and the one of "my friend" in line 9 make reference to Jessie Pope, a (singoistic = patriotic) poetess and journalist

She became famous during the war for writing several pro war poems and articles on British newspapers, that wanted to convince young British men to go to war

This poem had another title: "To a certain poetess" →then it was changed, but because of this change some scholars believe that "my friend" and "you" can be referred to members of the propaganda system in general

Owen had a similar but different story to Brooke →he was a volunteer too, but then he developed an antiwar position

He got a severe form of shell-shock →he was hospitalized at Craiglockhart hospital (Scottish hospital where shell shocks were sent) →after some months of treatment, they sent him to the front

He died only one week before the end of the war

1920s - 1930s in England

These years have 3 labels:

- the interwar years →purely historical

- the age of anxiety →intellectual atmosphere characterizing these years
- anglo-american modernism →most relevant cultural movement that developed during this period

The UK and US lived these years in very different ways for ? it was tuff →british economy started to have economic problems, and during the inter war years the british empire started collapsing

The real collapse happened after the WWII, but slowly starts here →in 1921 the british empire lost Ireland, its nearest colony →Eire, the Republic of Ireland was established

Northern Ireland remains part of the UK

Now the so known "irish troubles" (1921 - 1994) begin →in 1994 a truce was signed (not a peace treaty)

The irish troubles consisted in a civil war between northern irish catholics and northern irish anglicans →catholics wanted northern ireland to become part of the Eire, while anglicans wanted to remain part of the UK

Many riots and terroristic attacks →that happened in the UK too

The organization that organized these attacks was the I.R.A →irish republic army (catholic terroristic org.), that fought for making northern ireland part of Eire

In the 1930s, according to the Statute of Westminster, some colonies were given the state of "dominions" →not independent, but could be more autonomous →the UK was not able to control its empire with an iron fist anymore →they had to make some concessions

This does not happen however with India →after the WWII, with the process of decolonization, the english empire got dismantled

The 1920s - 1930s

In the USA the 1920s were a decade of prosperity (in UK they were hard times) → these years are known as "the roaring twenties"

A novel which reflects on the excess of this age is "The Great Gatsby" by Fitzgerald → the main characters are young rich people, but they are unable to reach happiness because they have to go through personal tragedies

These years ended in 1929 with the Wall Street crisis → so 1930s were hard times, until 1935 with the New Deal

But age of anxiety → ones mean the intellectual atmosphere that characterizes these years in the USA → most American intellectuals felt anxiety, due to the loss of certainties

That collective loss was caused by:

- the great war → it was a collective traumatic experience:
 - 10 million people died, mainly soldiers but also many civilians
 - it showed how cruel humans can be
 - shows how progress can be detrimental and devastating, if not controlled by ethics
- revolutionary theories → either elaborated in those years, or elaborated before but became accepted in the 20s and 30s → they contradicted many ideals those intellectuals believed in:
 - Darwin's theory → after WWI became actually accepted → it denies years of biblical education, and humans are not privileged creatures
 - Freud's theory → in particular his three part model of the human psyche → most of the psyche is dark and unexplored:
 - * id: unconscious, impulsive
 - * ego: the rational side
 - * super ego: moral norms humans are taught to live in society
 - Einstein's theory → theory of relativity, which made the concepts of time and space relative and not absolute
 - Bergson's theory → he elaborates a theory of time, according to which there are two types of time:
 - * external objective time, measured by clocks
 - * psychological, subjective time → called duration

- Frazer's theory →he is an anthropologist (science that originated in the second part of the 19th century, and studies human societies all around the world) →in particular primitive societies →in "The Golden Bough" he writes about his studies regarding some african societies, and says that even if they are primitive, these societies are complex and articulated = discovery clashes with imperialism →now some intellectuals (modernists) got interested in the culture of these populations

The second coming - William Butler Yeats

He is a modernist irish poet

By reading this poem, we can understand what it meant to be an intellectual during the age of anxiety

This poem was written in 1919 →the war had just finished and the europeans economies were devastated, + there the russian revolution just happened

Between 1919 and 1921 there was a civil war in Ireland, which concluded with the creation of the Free Republic of Ireland →then another one started in northern ireland ??

Yeats elaborated a personal theory of history →he believed that human history was divided into cycles lasting 2000 years each

He also gave a graphic representation of this cycles →each one has the shape of gyre

Two stanzas →the first one is objective (it presents a description of the world at the time) and shorter →the second subjective because it is about a vision of the future and longer

He was leaving in 1919, ending of the cycle that started with Christ's birth →the falcon cannot hear the falconer stands for this and is a metaphore →this means that the cycle is about to finish

Turning →is a diacope

Falcon and falconer is a polyptoton

Mere anarchy →there is not a political orientation in that world

The tide →refernce of the great world war

The world functions the other way around

There is a vision about the future, that lyrical eye has

The first coming was the birth of christ, now the new cycle begins with a second coming →it has not happened yet, he has a vision about the future

As the sun in the desert →simile

The new creature is monstrous one, a sphinx-like creature

Rocking cradle = culla ondeggiante

Jesus was born in Bethlem →the creature is anit-christ

The message is that the historical cycle is finishing, and a new one is going to start
→and nightmarish one

Yeats was an irish independentits →he also wrote political poems

Anglo modernism

Definition: *A cultural movement developing in the ENglish-speaking contries starting to emerge at the end of the 19th century, more clearly after the Great War, as a reaction against the wrongs of its age with its puritanical, authoritative, imperialistic and materialistic attitude. Modernism likewise reacted against the art of the past, considere as unable to represent and understand the modern world*

High modernism is the one that was born after the WWI

Modernist artists tried to find new ways to understand reality

The one before WWI went against past art →after they recognize the value of the art of the past, but this art has to be adapted

Angloamerican modernism

High modernism →early has a different behaviour towards tradition

Vorticism →resembles futurism Association of ideas

Ulysis is a rewriting of the odysse of Omer in a modern way

Leopold Bloom is a modern Ulysis

He is married to Molly (modern Penelope) →her main feature is being faithful →but she is not faithful to Leopold

Telemachus is his son, but not with Molly

Modernists:

- Joyce
- Virginia Woolf

1922 annus mirabilis

Waste land is a long narrative poem

Jane Eyre

Out there in the world

Last part is protofeminist →women should be able to do what they want to do

Sometimes she climbs to the rooftop and imagines the busy city

A good victorian woman was not supposed to be restless

My mind's eye →faculty of imagination →romantic background →also in word ear

"Women are supposed to be very calm" →beginning of protofeminist →but they are not, because they are just like men

Bertha Mason - page 56

Bertha belongs to two minorities: she is a woman and comes from the colony

She is locked in the attic →she is referred to in the novel as "The mad woman in the attic"

Bertha Mason is described as a villain →and is presented like an animal

Line 35 →use of irony for the description of married life →then compares Bertha to Jane

Night of Egypt →biblical reference

Jane is:

- outspoken
- endowed with a sense of justice →she gets furious
- restless →feels the need to travel
- imaginative →when she climbs to the rooftop, she imagines what the world is really like
- active →not a passive victorian woman
- rebellious →she praises to people that are rebelling
- she is also introspective

Recuperare 16 marzo

The wide sargasso sea - Jean Rhys

She is a postcolonial author →and writes "The wide sargasso sea", a postcolonial novel →west indies is the carabbieans

Antoinette had a tragic childhood →her father died, she was neglected by her mother and had financial problems →but starting from 1963, the economic situation became worse because slavery was abolished →luckly she married a rich man

Bertha never speaks in the novel →she is only a crazy and animalesque woman (in Jane Eyre) →here she is beatufl

No onmiscent narrators →and the novel has 3 parts →Rochester is a vile goldigger and is not a reliable as a narrator, and Bertha too (she has mental issues)

Antoinette had burnt the Thornfield Hall

It is a prequel and a rewriting of Jane Eyre →part three is a rewriting, the facts of the first 2 parts take place before

Her mother was a Creole, term thas has 3 meanings:

- white person of european descent, however born and raised in the colony →Antoinette is an example
- it can also be of mixed ethnicity
- creole languages are a blend of one or even two european languages and a native one

Jean Rhys was too progressive and was not appreciated

Rochester felt a sense of displancement as he was in the West Indies →while Antoinette felt displaced in England

A disappointing colonial marriage - extract

In part two the narrator is Rochester

Rocherster is describing his newly married wife (antoinette) and describes how she talks to Caroline, a servant →he is not used to being this nice to servants

He imagines talking to his father →he says that he has accomplished something: he has married a rich girl →Rocherster was a disappointment to his father

Constant rain that is not puring = drizzle →but here the rain is intense

His british mindset finds unacceptable the close relationship between Antoinette and her servant

He also disapproves of Antoinette to be too wild →she runs in the rain to meet the servant

He describes her eyes as alien = different

In Jane Eyre Bertha is of mixed race →so there are racist remarks by some characters →here Antoinette is white, but only had european origins →she is still inferior for this reason

Antoine brought to the table 30.000 pounds as the dowry →he sees the marriage as a financial transaction →he marries her for the money

He despise both creoles and natives →Mr. Rochester here is vulnerable, has no moral →he is not presented like an imperialistic hero

Extract from part III

Here Antoinette is the narrator

She is an alcoholic and abuses Antoinette

Sometimes Antoinette has visions →and when she was a kid, she sees her mother

When she went to England, she was locked in the attic →she thought that London was an illusion

The strange case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde

Stevenson

Stevenson was born in Scotland →in a rich respectable presbyterian family (protestant)

He lived an unconventional life →he rebelled to his background and led a life that was not common for the middle class

His parents wanted him to become a lawyer, but he became a professional writer →for which he had a less stable income

He traveled extensively both to the continent to other places →he had to travel for health related issues →and the humid Scottish environment was not suitable for him

He then left Europe and settled on the Samoa Islands on the Pacific Ocean

He loved living there, and got along with the native population →he doesn't have a colonial sense of superiority

He wrote some poems but is mainly known as a prose writer →he wrote short stories and novels

He wrote:

- adventure novels, like "Treasure Island"
- set in Scotland, like "Kidnapped"
- historical, like "The Anarchist" set in the middle ages
- "The strange case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr Hyde" →whose genre is not easy to define →it is both science fiction, crime and psychological novel:
 - science fiction too because the impossible is achieved through science →he divided the good and part of the human mind using powders
 - crime because crimes are committed
 - psychological →because it is an insight in the human mind
 - also epistolar, because part of the novel consists of letters

There are several narrators, like Utterson, Dr. Jekyll and another one →their point of view is limited, they are not omniscient, and are not reliable mainly with Dr. Jekyll, who in his final statement might be lying to us

Questions

Q1

Mr Utterson was a lawyer, and was a serious and respectable gentleman →he had a long time friendship with Mr Enfield, with whom he walked around London without talking much

Q2

One day they witnessed something →they were walking and noticed a run-down shabby building with a colored door →at the moment Enfield told Mr Utterson "the story of the door"

Some time before he saw a primitive and beast like man who had bumped into a girl, and walked on her →the crowd got furious and obliged him to give the family a compensation →he had no cash so gave a check, signed not by Mr Hyde but by Dr Jekyll (a client and close friend of Utterson)

That event was really disturbing, for Enfield, but also for Utterson, who hears about that accident from him →it came as a shock: Jekyll was a respectable man

Q3

Utterson took a look at the new testament made by Jekyll, according to which all his possessions would go to Mr Hyde after his death →this was strange

He decided to talk to Lanyon, another friend, who shared scientific interests like the ones of Jekyll →but they grew apart, and thought that Dr Jekyll experiments were unethical and unorthodox (same concept of Frankenstein)

Utterson decided to meet Mr Hyde in person →they met, and his first impression was negative, because Hyde was rude and ugly

Q4

Jekyll invited Utterson for dinner, and Utterson wanted to have a word with him about Mr Hyde →Jekyll got nervous and told him to mind his own business

Q5

One night a girl named?, who was sitting by the window, witnessed a crime →a man killed a member of the British parliament, Sir Danvers Carew, (MP) and was a brutal murder

The murder was so brutal she fainted →she then called the police, and Utterson reported Hyde →but Hyde disappeared

Dr Jekyll became social now and starting to meet his friend regularly, but after some time he started to spend most of his time in his lab again

Q6

One day Mr Lanyon gets sick and dies →but first he is visited by Utterson, but he doesn't want to tell him what happened →he hands him a letter, that had to be opened after Jekyll's death or disappearance

Q7

One night Poole, Jekyll's butler, visits him in a state of agitation →he heard strange noises coming from the lab →but the lab was locked and the servants couldn't get in. So he uses an axe to open the door, and he finds Mr Hyde wearing baggy clothes (as if they belonged to someone else)

Q8

Mr Jekyll couldn't be found, so Utterson reads a statement that Jekyll left and the letter of Lanyon →in the letter, he says that Hyde and Jekyll are the same person. One day Lanyon was visited by Hyde and wanted a drug, and in front of him he drank the potion and transformed into Dr Jekyll.

The strange case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde - Final statement

QA

The narrator is Jekyll, as Hyde was going to win over him →while he is still lucid, he (1) writes this statement and (2) kills himself

QB

He talks about himself →he says that he belonged to a rich family, had good education and thinks that he is a respectable victorian gentleman

However, he says that he has passed times that are unspeakable and would not be approved by his friends and family →he did something unacceptable, but he doesn't tell precisely

QC

He started to study the duality of the human psyche →everybody has an evil and a good side

He believes there there could be even more sides

QD

He wanted to separate the two sides and to suppress the evil one →so that humans could only be good

Does this recall Frankenstein's purpose? →Victor wanted also to vanish diseases from humanity

QE

He created a medicine which is the mixture of different powders

QF

The first time he felt free from moral constricts and enjoyed the transformation into Mr Hyde →he could follow his instincts without moral

He puts an end to his life to end Hyde's life too

QG

One night he woke up and found out that he turned into Hyde without taking the drug

Wrap up

Not easy to define the genre → hybrid novel: science-fiction, psychological and crime
The style is realistic → it is still a Victorian novel → characters are typically Victorian men living in London

There are 4 narrators → they all have limited point of views (not omniscient) and some are not reliable, for example Dr Jekyll

It is set in London → which is partly described in a realistic way, but it is also rendered as a sort of labyrinth → it is made of streets that create a sort of maze?

The scenes tend to happen at night

The main themes are:

- the double: the protagonist has two personalities
- darwinism: it is relevant in this novel when it comes to:
 - Mr Hyde seems to be a previous stage of evolution of a human being → he looks like a primitive man
 - however Mr Hyde takes control of Dr Jekyll → so he seems to be the fittest according to Darwin's theory, and Jekyll will perish in favor of Mr Hyde

The two sides of his mind reflect two styles of life: a life of respectability (Jekyll) or a free but deprived life (Hyde)

See which narrators are more reliable

Sherlock Holmes is very smart, and his ability as investigator can be seen because he can make brilliant deductions starting from clues → he has a deductive method

Utterton acts similarly and Stevenson was probably influenced by Conan Doyle

The first English author to write about Faustus was Marlowe, who wrote about a scientist who went with the devil to have unlimited knowledge and have power over other people

Faustus becomes the first over-achiever in English literature → the following over-achievers are Victor, Watson and Jekyll (who conducted immoral experiments)

This is still a Victorian novel, but is also characterized by a sharp symbolism → city of London, the house, scenes set at night = form of clear symbolism → something that the average Victorian novel doesn't do (the main goal is realism)

Oscar Wilde

Life

He was an Irish author, but spent a lot of time in England →until he was 20 he lived in Dublin, where he was born in 1884 from a middleclass family →father doctor, mother intellectual

Both his parents were Irish independentists →they believed in Ireland independence (was a colony, and only in 1921 Ireland achieved independence)

His parents were fervant nationalists, however he had not that political commitment
He attended Ireland's most prestigious university (Trinity college) →once he had graduated, he moved to England because of studying reasons →he attended Oxford university

Here he studied greek, latin and foreign languages →after graduating from Oxford, he remained and moved in London, where he became a celebrety because of:

- his literary works
- for his lifestyle

He had an eccentric lifestyle →he was a dandy: he wore eccentric and colorful clothes, and was a sophisticated speaker →he used wit extensevly →he was also very sensitive to beauty and art

He became so famous that he was invited to the USA (like Dickens) to hold conferences there

He got married and had two children →but he started a homosexual relationship with a young man, who belonged to one of the most powerful families in England →Lord Alfred Douglas, son of Marquis of Queensberry

When Marquis of Queensberry knew this, publicly accused Oscar Wilde of homosexuality (which was prohibited)

Wilde brought him to court and a trial for defamation started →but the marquis showed evidences and brough witnesses →so the marquis was declared not guilty, and two other trials against Wilde started →he was accused of obscene acts

In this moment, Wilde was actually at the peak of his popularity →so the trials were extensevly covered by the english press

He was mainly a playwright

In the end he was declared guilty →this was a blow to his reputation and career (all his plays got canceled) →he was sentenced to hard labor

As he was released, he moved to Paris where he lived in poverty, and died in the year 1900

Additionally, his wife and children did not want to have anything to do with him →the two children declared that they would have joined the war to was away the shame that Oscar Wilde had brought to their family

Works

- poetry →"The ballad of Reading Gaol (jail)" →published after his release from prison, and here he reflects on the hardship of life in prison
- prose (for which he is mainly famous) →he wrote short stories intended originally as bedtime stories for his children, like "The happy prince", "The Canterville Ghost" (short novel), "The picture of Dorian Gray" (only full novel), "De profundis" (which is non-fiction, it is a letter he wrote to Lord Douglas)
- plays, extremely popular →"Salomey" (biblical story, the princess who beheaded John Baptiste) →the other are society plays (they satirize the english society): "Lady Windermere's Fan", "A woman of no importance", "An ideal husband", "The importance of being earnest" →extensive use of wit and irony

The canterville Ghost

A family came from USA →father politician and rich, mother was a philanthropy →the Otis family, of 6 members

There are 4 children:

- eldest son, whose name is Washington (really patriotic name) →really pragmatic and almost utilitarian and materialistic
- girl Virginia, who is sensitive and empathic instead
- two twins, having patriotic names: Star and Stripes →and they are very naughty

They moved to the UK after buying a beautiful castle which belonged to Lord Canterville, who sold the castle because it was haunted by the ghost of a previous Canterville who had lived during the Renaissance

He was a ghost because he killed his wife for a very silly reason, she could not cook
The ghost tries to make the life of the family impossible, but the family is materialistic and is not successful →he gets depressed, but Virginia helps him to come to terms with his crime and finally goes to the afterlife

Oscar Wilde

He is considered part of an international literary movement known as "aestheticism" → it originated in France, in the mid 19th century, and then spread all around Europe. In Britain Walter Pater brought it and popularized it → he was an intellectual and was Wilde's professor at Oxford university.

However, Wilde is considered the most relevant member of this movement in Britain. It is based on the principle of "Art for art's sake", according to which literature (and art in general) has got no practical purpose, and should not be produced to convey a moral message or to teach something.

Art is a mere expression of beauty → art should have no moral and no political commitment → and realism does not have to be a feature.

Aestheticism is not a Victorian movement → Victorians focused on moralism, utilitarianism and realism.

Oscar Wilde is also a member of the "Decadence", which is more of a cultural atmosphere than a movement (as something that developed in a non planned way).

Decadence has two meanings:

- because of the scandal decadent writers were creating with their literary production and lifestyle → it happens with Oscar Wilde
- decadent writers were giving voice to a sense of ending for the age they were living in and for its middle-class hypocritical values → the Victorian society was going to finish

The happy prince

It was not intended for publication, it was intended as a bedtime story for his children. The city is unknown, but there is a port → and there is a colossal statue of the happy prince.

Questions:

1. it was beautiful and full of gold and diamonds
2. people appreciated it for its beauty and for the moral message it was conveying → one has to enjoy life
3. a little bird landed on the statue and he was flying alone, headed to Egypt
4. he had a privileged life and did not know about suffering
5. he was crying because he had to see the suffering of the people of the city

6. to become his messenger with the aim to bring parts of him to poor people
7. she was a seamstress and her son was ill, and in order to take care of him he could not work properly
8. he helps a writer, who cannot concentrate because of the cold (he is poor)
9. helps then a little girl whose eggs she was selling got broken and father would have beaten her
10. in heaven, the spirits of the bird and the prince meet in the presence of god

Moral messages are generosity, happiness comes from sharing, appearance does not matter, + religious messages → so it is not really related to the principle of aestheticism

However there is a reference to beauty and art, which is typical of aestheticism

Picture of Dorian Gray

The first edition was published in the year 1890 on an American magazine (not in the UK) → it was published as a volume in the UK in 1891, together with a preface which is extremely relevant, and is considered the manifesto of British aestheticism

While the preface of the "Lyrical ballads" was the manifesto of British romanticism

Plot on page 126 → ASK NOTES ABOUT PLOT

Picture of Dorian Gray

Preface

It is regarded as the manifesto of english aestetism →here there is a series of aphorisms

Aphorism = it is a short clever statement (witty) intended to express a general truth
Some of these aphorisms are contradictory, some of them are even obscure (its meaning is not clear) →other are controversial and provoking

Main points made in the preface?

Aph. 1 →"The artist is the creator of beautiful things" →serves the "art of art's sake" concept

Aph. 2 →"To reveal art and to conceal the artist is art's aim"

"Those who find ugly meanings ... charming" →art should not express anything other than beauty

"There is no such thing as an immoral book ... that is all" →art is not about moral ideas

Preface in "Lyrical ballads" →the language was simple: it was used by pure people, and to create a cultural revolution (to make up for the failure of the political one)

Caliban is the co-protagonist of the Tempest in Shakespeare →the monstrous creature

"The artist can express anything"

"The type of all the arts is the art of the musician" →explain?

"All art is at one .."

ASK THIS PART ABOUT UNDERLING THINS, IMPORTANT

Point number 7 ??

He has an elitist vision of art →only people with the cultural means can understand it

The studio

The studio is sorrouned by a beautiful garden →in line with aestetism →+ expressive objects

Exotic form of art →there isn't any condemnation of forms of art that are not western (japanese art mentioned)

One night Basil visits Dorian, he shows him the portrait (which has become the portrait of an ugly man) and killed the painter, who he considers to be the cause

Academy is too mainstream and vulgar →the other one no

Aphorism said by Lord Henry

One night Dorian and Cicil's brother were sitting in the same opium den →he wants

revenge, recognizes him because he gets called the "Prince charming" →he tries to kill him, but Dorian convinces him he is not doriang because he is too young
Basil is smart, so he cannot be handsome →the opposite is valid for Dorian →if you are too beautiful or too smart you will have a hard life →is better to be stupid or ugly
Dorian will cause other people to suffer and will suffer himself →prophecy